

CM Rekha, Nabin lead Tiranga Yatra from India Gate to Kartavya Path

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A grand Tiranga Yatra was held on Wednesday from India Gate to Kartavya Path under the leadership of Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta. The yatra took place in the presence of BJP National President and MP Nitin Nabin and Delhi BJP President Harsh Malhotra, with thousands of school and college students, NCC cadets, and NSS volunteers carrying the Tricolour along the route

from India Gate via Rafi Marg to Kartavya Path.

Delhi Cabinet Ministers Parvesh Sahib Singh, Ashish Sood, Manjinder Singh Sirsa, and Ravindra Indraj Singh were also present. The yatra was organised by the Delhi Government as part of the nationwide Har Ghar Tiranga campaign ahead of Independence Day on August 15.

The participation of school and college students alongside NCC cadets and NSS volunteers was a central

feature of the event. Carrying the national flag through the route, the young participants reflected both the scale of the mobilisation and the government's effort to link the independence anniversary to active youth involvement in public civic expression.

The Chief Minister said August 15 is not only a celebration of independence but also an opportunity to reflect on India's development journey since independence across fields



including science, technology, the economy, education, and infrastructure. She said

the journey represents the hard work and collective contribution of crores of cit-

izens, and Independence Day gives an opportunity to measure how far the country has come from where it started.

She urged every Delhi resident to hoist the Tricolour at their home and share selfies with the flag on social media. She described Har Ghar Tiranga not merely as a campaign but as a collective expression of respect, pride, and unity toward the nation.

BJP National President Nitin Nabin said Har Ghar Tiranga has become a pow-

erful campaign of public participation at the call of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, with people from every section of society joining with respect for the Tricolour and pride in the nation.

Nabin urged people to participate in the Har Ghar Tiranga campaign on August 13, 14 and 15 by hoisting the national flag at their houses and taking selfies with it. On 13, 14, and 15 August, for three days, the honour of the Tricolour must be carried forward in every

home. The Tricolour must be hoisted at our homes, selfies must be taken with it, and the resolve must be taken that we will build their own future and adopt the resolve of building and developing India's future," he said.

The Har Ghar Tiranga campaign, which the central government has been running since 2022 as part of the Azadi Ka Amrit Mahotsav, encourages every household to hoist the national flag in the days surrounding Independence Day.

Bicycles procured under GeM, followed transparent process: Sood

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Rejecting the Aam Aadmi Party's allegation of irregularities, Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood on Wednesday said that bicycles were procured under the Vidya Vahini scheme through the Government e-marketplace (GeM) following a transparent bidding process.

Addressing a press conference, Sood said, "AAP is completely flustered and trembling with panic after seeing the joyful faces of over 3,000 young girls receiving brand-new bicycles. They are not just scammers; they are daily fabricators of fake percentages. One day they claim 90 crore, then 75 per cent, then 70 per cent, and then 43 per cent. Their changing figures expose their political desperation."

"The inconsistency in the Aam Aadmi Party's allegations is evident in how their alleged figures for the bicycle procurement kept changing day-by-day: starting at 70 per cent commission on August 3, shifting to 40 per cent commission (a ₹36 crore loss out of a ₹90 crore overall scam) on August 6, adjusting to 43 per cent and 66 per cent commission on August 7, and ultimately claiming a 75 per cent Figure on August 8," Sood stated.

Sood said that more than 3,000 girl students had received bicycles in the first phase of the scheme and dismissed questions being raised over the procurement process. "Our bicycles are



Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood during a press conference at the Delhi Secretariat in New Delhi

bought from GeM. GeM has been a transparent portal for 10 years," Sood said. He said bids floated on the portal were subject to prescribed parameters and that a bid could not proceed if it contained a restrictive clause or if a complaint against it remained unresolved.

Sood also sought to explain the procurement process by comparing it with the purchase of consumer products, saying the government was required to follow the prescribed tender process rather than approach a particular manufacturer or vendor.

His remarks came amid criticism from the opposition over the quality and price of bicycles being distributed to students under the scheme.

Alleging irregularities in the Delhi government's bicycle distribution scheme for Class 9 girl students, the Aam Aadmi Party on Wednesday said it would approach the Anti-Corruption Branch or the Central Bureau of Investigation if Chief

Minister Rekha Gupta does not take action on the matter.

Addressing a press conference, senior AAP leader Saurabh Bharadwaj alleged that bicycles being distributed under the 'Vidya Vahini' scheme were of inferior quality compared to those mentioned in the tender.

Sood also attacked AAP for criticising the BJP Government's welfare measures, including the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana, under which eligible women are being provided ₹2,500 per month.

He also referred to discussions on the Delhi Right of Citizens to Time-Bound Delivery of Services Bill, amendments related to slum clusters and the Delhi Fire Service Amendment Bill, saying these measures were aimed at improving governance and public services.

On the bicycle scheme, Sood said the government was happy to see thousands of girls receive the bicycles and rejected the opposition's criticism of the initiative.

Security tightened across Capital ahead of I-Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Ahead of Independence Day, security has been stepped up across the national capital, with Delhi Police intensifying patrolling, vehicle checks and surveillance to prevent any unlikely incident during the August 15 celebrations.

Delhi Police has conducted a special 'general gasht' - a coordinated night-patrolling exercise - across the capital and its 15 police districts as part of the security arrangements ahead of Independence Day, with maximum personnel deployed on roads and at strategic locations, officials said on Wednesday.

The three-hour exercise was conducted from 11 pm to 2 am on the intervening night of Tuesday-Wednesday, with senior officers supervising security arrangements and checking the preparedness of

personnel deployed at various pickets. The exercise was aimed at preventing criminal activities, maintaining law and order and ensuring that streets remained safe and sanitised ahead of August 15 celebrations, a senior police officer said.

Police personnel across districts have been deployed on the streets, while additional pickets and checkpoints have been established at several locations. Officers said the focus is on identifying suspicious persons and vehicles, keeping a close watch on criminal elements and ensuring heightened security with Independence Day in sight.

Police teams conducted checking of cars, suspicious vehicles and persons, while special attention was paid to traffic violations such as riding without helmets and triple riding, he said.

"Malls, abandoned vehicles and parking lots were



checked, while border pickets were strengthened with maximum staff on duty," another officer said.

Personnel assigned specific duties for Independence Day arrangements were exempted from the patrolling exercise, the officer said.

Hotels and other establishments were also checked as part of the exercise, along with sensitive locations, important installations, vul-

Assembly Monsoon Session ends; 4 Bills passed, 2 CAG reports tabled

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The three-day Monsoon Session of the Delhi Legislative Assembly concluded with four bills passed, two CAG reports tabled, and 52 public matters raised under Rule 280. Speaker Vijender Gupta also criticised the "irresponsible attitude" of the opposition MLAs during the session, which began on August 7 and concluded on Tuesday.

Addressing a press conference on Wednesday, Gupta said the House functioned for a total of 13.19 hours, in which two CAG (Comptroller and Auditor General) reports were tabled, and 52 public interest issues were raised under Rule 280. Gupta highlighted that 23 members were given the opportunity to raise public issues in a single day, breaking the previous practice of a daily limit of 10 members. Despite an Opposition of 22 members, around 20 attended the House alongside 44 to 45 of the 48



ruling party members.

The four bills passed during the session were the Delhi Bed and Breakfast Establishments Repeal Bill, 2026; the Delhi Right of Citizens to Time-Bound and Ease of Delivery of Services Bill, 2026; the Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board Amendment Bill, 2026; and the Delhi Fire Service Amendment Bill, 2026. According to Gupta, since the commencement of the Eighth Delhi Legislative Assembly till date, a total of 19 CAG Reports have been tabled

in the House. He said action on the reports must be taken in a time-bound manner to reach a logical conclusion.

He said in this assembly session, the first-ever AI-based live transcription and translation system in any Indian legislative assembly is also piloted. He added that the session lasted 13 hours and 19 minutes.

Pointing to the absence of Aam Aadmi Party leader Atishi in the House, he said it was for the first time that a leader of opposition had remained absent through the entire session. Agreements and disagreements happen, but not attending the session was unfortunate, he said.

"AAP seems to have become leaderless. I even asked the opposition members to depute someone else from among themselves to function as the leader of opposition in Atishi's absence, but nothing happened," the Speaker said. On conduct, Gupta expressed anguish over what he described as unparliamentary behav-

iour by certain Opposition members inside the House and within the Assembly premises, including creating disorder, throwing objects, including rice, using abusive language, and forcing the intervention of Marshals on all three days.

On legislative pace, Gupta drew a sharp contrast with the previous seventh Assembly, which held only five sessions across its entire five-year tenure. The current eighth Assembly has conducted six sessions in under one-and-a-half years. Members actively raised civic concerns, including garbage disposal, waterlogging, stray cattle, PWD roads, and electricity bills, during the session.

The House held a two-day Short Duration Discussion on the role of political leaders in the North-East Delhi riots and the issue of punishment. The House also unanimously passed a congratulatory motion on the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana and paid tributes to former MLAs and victims of tragic fire incidents across Delhi.

NORTHERN RAILWAY NOTICE INVITING TENDER	
Name of work and its location:-	103-SRDEE-G-DLI-2026-27. Provision of compact sub-station and outdoor feeder pillar at TKJ Railway Colony, New Delhi.
Approx cost of the works in:-	Rs. 7734060.00/-
Address of the office:-	Sr. Divil Elect. Engineer/General, DRM Office, Delhi Division, Northern Railway, State Entry Road, New Delhi-110055
Earnest Money:-	Rs. 154700.00/-
Last Date & time of submission of tender:-	03.09.2026, 13.00 Hrs.
Opening of tender:-	03.09.2026, 13.00 Hrs.
Website & notice board :-	www.ireps.gov.in & Sr. Divl. Elect. Engineer/General, New Delhi.
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 2786/2026	

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform the general public that our client Ramesh Kumar S/o Sh. Laxman Dass R/o 4/128, Subhash Nagar New Delhi-110027 have disowned & debarred his son Atul Kumar from all his movable and immovable properties & have severed all relations with him. Any person dealing with him in any manner whatsoever shall be doing so at his/her own cost, risk, and responsibility. Our client and his family members shall not be held responsible for any of their acts.
ROHIT YADAV (ADVOCATE) Ch. no. 402, Civil Side Tisraizari, Delhi-110054

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM | অসম চৰকাৰ
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER | মুখ্য অভিযন্তাৰ কাৰ্যালয়:-
PWD BUILDING | লোক নিৰ্মাণ (গৃহ) বিভাগ:-
ASSAM:- GUWAHATI - 31 অসম:- গুৱাহাটী- ৩
No. নিবিদা প্ৰসংগ নং-CE/TB-II(Bldg.)/39/2026/3

PRESS NOTICE
নিবিদা আহ্বান কৰা জাননী
The Chief Engineer, PWD (Building), Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-03 on behalf of the Governor of Assam, invites bid through Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) Mode- I of contract for the work detailed in the table below, from eligible Firm/Contractor of reputed having experience in similar nature of work. Details of bid may be seen at e-procurement portal i.e. www.assamtenders.gov.in
The bidders must be enrolled with e-tendering web portal www.assamtenders.gov.in
মুখ্য অভিযন্তা, লোক নিৰ্মাণ (গৃহ) বিভাগ অসম, চান্দমাৰী, গুৱাহাটী-০৩ এ অসম চৰকাৰৰ ৰাজ্যপালৰ হৈ তলত উল্লেখ কৰা কামৰ বাবে অভিজ্ঞতা থকা প্ৰতিষ্ঠিত ফাৰ্ম/টিকাদাৰৰ পৰা অভিযান্ত্ৰিক, ক্ৰয় আৰু নিৰ্মাণ (EPC) পদ্ধতি-১ ৰ নিবিদা আহ্বান কৰিছে। নিবিদাৰ সবিশেষ তথ্য ই-প্ৰক্ৰিউৰমেণ্ট পৰ্টেল www.assamtenders.gov.in ত চাব পাৰিব।
নিবিদা কাৰ্যসূচীসকলে ই-টেন্ডাৰ ৱেব পৰ্টেল www.assamtenders.gov.in ৰ জৰিয়তে পঞ্জীয়ন কৰিব লাগিব।

Sl. No. ক্ৰ. নং	Name of work কামৰ নাম	Approx. Value of work (in Rs) কামৰ আনুমানিক মূল্য (টকাত)	Bid Security নিবিদা পত্ৰ সুৰক্ষা	Bid Processing Fee নিবিদা প্ৰক্ৰিয়াকৰণ মূল্য (টকাত)	Completion period সম্পূৰ্ণ কৰাৰ সময়সীমা
1.	Construction of Composite Court Complex for Karimganj District Judiciary, along with Boundary wall at Karimganj (G+5 storied building with future provision G+6 storey)	43,76,09,192.00 ৪৩,৭৬,০৯,১৯২.০০	2 % for General category or 1 % for Reserved category on value of work	Rs. 20,000.00 ২০,০০০.০০ টকা	36 (Thirty Six) Months ৩৬ (ছয়গ্ৰিহ) মাহ
১.	কাৰিমগঞ্জ জিলা ন্যায়িক ব্যৱস্থাৰ বাবে এক সংযুক্ত আদালত চৌহদ আৰু ইয়াৰ সৈতে সীমাৰ প্ৰাচীৰ (Boundary wall) নিৰ্মাণ কাৰিমগঞ্জ, অসম (ভৱিষ্যতে G+6 মহলা নিৰ্মাণৰ সুবিধাসহ G+5 মহলাীয়া অট্টালিকা)।		সাধাৰণ শ্ৰেণীৰ বাবে কামৰ মূল্যৰ ২% আৰু সংৰক্ষিত শ্ৰেণীৰ বাবে ১%		

Note টোকা:
(i) Value of work may vary according to the detail NIT. কামৰ মূল্য বিতংভাৱে আহ্বান কৰা নিবিদা জাননী অনুযায়ী পৰিৱৰ্তন হ'ব পাৰে।
(ii) All terms and conditions will be as per the Bidding Documents. সকলো চৰ্ত আৰু নিয়মাৱলী নিবিদা নথিপত্ৰ অনুযায়ী হ'ব।
(iii) The Press Notice will be a part of the Bidding Documents. নিবিদা আহ্বান কৰা জাননী নিবিদা নথিপত্ৰৰ অংশ হ'ব

Chief Engineer, PWD (Building)
Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3.
মুখ্য অভিযন্তা, লোক নিৰ্মাণ (গৃহ) বিভাগ, অসম, চান্দমাৰী, গুৱাহাটী-৩।

DIPR/C/PIO/11 12/13-Aug-26

The Pioneer
Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Dhakane Sudam Vitthal, Father of Dhakne Yogesh Sudam, R/o- Saigaon, Tel- Yeola, Dist- Nashik, Maharashtra- 423402, have changed my name from Dhakane Sudam Vitthal to Sudam Vitthal Dhakne, Vide Affidavit Dated 12/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Dhakne Madhuri Yogesh, W/o Dhakne Yogesh Sudam, R/o- Saigaon, Tel- Yeola, Dist- Nashik, Maharashtra- 423402, have changed my name from Dhakne Madhuri Yogesh to Madhuri Yogesh Dhakane, Vide Affidavit Dated 12/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Mansha Kunwar, W/o No.6945735X Hav Bhupendra Singh Chouhan, R/o- Vill & PO- Hasalpur, Teh- Mhow, Dist- Indore, M.P.- 453661, have changed my name from Mansha Kunwar Chouhan, vide affidavit dated 12/08/2026 before SDM, Delhi Cantt.

I, Savitri, Mother of- No.17028396K Nk Dipak, R/o- 37 Gram- Jalalkhedhi Dewas, Jalalkhedhi Agrod Dewas, M.P.- 455001, have changed my name from Harisingh to Harinarayan Parihar, vide affidavit No. IN-DL74624502156255Y dated 12/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Akshay Kumar Verma, S/o Sh. Vijay Kumar Verma R/o 46/16, East Azad Nagar, Gali No. 16, Krishna Nagar, Delhi 110051, declare that I have changed my name from Akshay Kumar Verma to Akshay Chattha for all future purchases.

I, Vishuna Devi, Mother of No.16020644K Hav Raju, R/o- Ward No.8, Kirranch Road Porsa, Teh - Porsa, Dist- Morena, M.P, have changed my name from Vishuna Devi to Visuna Devi, vide affidavit dated 12/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Shri Jagdish Sharma, Father of No.15719188N LNK Arpit Sharma, R/o- 39 Harisiddhi Road, Ujjain, M.P - 456006, have changed my name from Shri Jagdish Sharma to Jagdish Sharma, vide affidavit dated 12/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

COMPREHENSIVE ANNUAL MAINTENANCE CONTRACT
E-Tender Notice No.: RN-ST-19-2026-27; Date: 10-08-2026. E-tenders are invited by the undersigned for the following work. Name of Work: Comprehensive Annual Maintenance Contract of EFFTRONIC MAKE DATA LOGGER for a period of 2 (Two) years in BG-I section (Changsarai-Dangla) of Rangiya Division. Tender Value: ₹65,30,233.44; Earnest Money: ₹1,30,600.00; E-tender will be closed at 15:00 hrs. on 07-09-2026 and Opened at 15:30 hrs. on 07-09-2026 at Sr. DSTE/Rangiya's office. The complete information with the tender document of above e-tender will be available in website www.ireps.gov.in
DRM (S&T)/Rangiya
NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY
"Serving Customers with a smile"

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the general public that Smt. Kaninika Joshi, Smt. Vinita Pandey, and Smt. Meenakshi Tripathi are the lawful and absolute owners of Property No. C-222, Madhuban, Delhi-110092. If any person, entity, bank, financial institution, or any other party holds any right, ownership, interest, mortgage, lien, claim, objection, or any other legal claim regarding the said property, they are requested to contact the undersigned in writing within 7 (seven) days from the date of publication of this notice, along with the necessary documents supporting their claim. Phone: +91 98732 35288Email: jain46380@gmail.com.
Sd/-Pankaj Jain (Advocate)
Ch. No. 491, Western Wing, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi - 54

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Rail Coach Naveenikaran Karkhana, Sonipat (Tender Notice)
Invitation of tender through E-tendering (e-Procurement Systems)

NIT No.	11-RCNK-OPN-RWH-2026
Name of Work and its location:	Tender for "Repairing Work of Rain Water Harvesting System of Factory and Colony Premises of RCNKS/NP (As per Scope of Work)."
Approx Cost of work:	Rs. 30,14,144.80/- including GST (Rs. Thirty Lakh Fourteen Thousand One Hundred Forty-Four & Paise Eighty only)
Earnest Money	Rs. 60300.00/-
Completion period of work	03 months from date of LOA
Cost of Tender document on cash/by post	NIL
Date and Time for submission/Closing of tender	Upto 15:00 hrs on 03/09/2026
Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen:	Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in
Tender No. 11-RCNK-OPN-RWH-2026 Dated:	12/08/2026 2787/2026
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE	

RUNGTA IRRIGATION LIMITED
REGD. & HEAD OFFICE:
101, Pragati Tower 26, Rajendra Place, New Delhi 110008
Tel: 011-4045330, 331, 332
CIN : L74899DL1998PLC023934
E-mail: info@rungtairrigation.in
Website: www.rungtairrigation.in

Statement of Unaudited financial results for the quarter ended June 30, 2026
The board of directors of the Company, at the meeting held on August 11, 2026 approved the Unaudited financial results of the Company for the quarter ended 30th June, 2026.
The Financial results along with the Auditors' Limited Review Report, have been uploaded at https://www.bseindia.com/xml-data/corpfiling/AttachLive/0b995080-fd6d-4269-94b9-75461e660d76.pdf and can be accessed by scanning the QR code:

By order of the Board
For Rungta Irrigation Limited
Sd/-
Shruti Jain
Whole-Time Director
DIN: 00229045

Place: New Delhi
Date: August 11, 2026

DDA approves UBBL-2016 amendments to simplify building plans

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) on Wednesday approved amendments to Unified Building Bye-Laws (UBBL)-2016 to simplify the building plan to reduce compliance burden and improve Ease of Doing Business at the meeting chaired by the Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Wednesday.

Apart from this, important decisions included the policy for reconstruction and redevelopment of old DDA-built two-storey units and the change of land use for the

development of the Metro Depot of the Rithala-Kundli Corridor in Narela Sub-City for expansion of the metro corridor. The meeting was attended by DDA vice chairman N. Saravana Kumar, chief secretary Rajiv Verma, and other members of the Authority.

In a statement, the DDA said the Authority has approved amendments to Unified Building Bye-Laws (UBBL)-2016 to simplify the building plan approval process. It seeks to de-link the prior requirement of obtaining No Objection Certificates (NOCs) from the Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC), Chief Inspector of Factories (CIF),

Delhi Jal Board (DJB) and Forest Department for obtaining building permits. This reform is aimed at reducing procedural delays and enabling faster project approvals.

Addressing a long-standing demand from residents and public representatives, the Authority approved a comprehensive policy enabling the reconstruction and redevelopment of DDA-built two-storey dwelling units on individual plots in older housing schemes (such as Naraina Vihar) and extending it across all similarly placed schemes in Delhi.

Developed under MPD-1962, several old DDA housing



schemes consist of built-up two-storey units on individual plots that are over 50 years old and structurally deficient. While vacant residential plots have clear redevelopment guidelines under prevailing MPD norms, built-up two-storey units lacked a uniform

framework. With this approval, built-up two-storey units are now granted redevelopment rights on par with vacant residential plots.

Reconstruction will be governed by plot size, prevailing MPD provisions, structural safety certifications, and com-

pliance with Unified Building Bye-laws, applicable FAR, ground coverage, height norms, and fire safety requirements. The redevelopment will be subject to applicable conversion charges, betterment levy (where applicable), and scrutiny fees, among others.

For expansion of metro corridor in the Narela and adjoining areas, the Authority has approved change of Land Use (CLU) of land measuring 19.63 Ha. from "Recreational" and "Public & Semi Public (PSP)" to "Transportation" for development of Metro Depot of Rithala-Kundli Corridor in Narela Sub-City (Zone P-I).

The extension of the Delhi Metro Red Line from Rithala to Kundli shall be a transformative project designed to strengthen urban mobility and regional integration with the approved Metro Depot acting as its epicentre. The metro line extension is expected to provide seamless connectivity and reduce travel time for thousands of daily passengers who currently rely on congested road networks by directly linking North West Delhi, Rohini and Narela Sub-Cities with Haryana.

This improved access is expected to stimulate development in the sub-cities, serving DDA's new residential

projects, the proposed University Hub at Narela Sub-City which falls along the route while also attracting investments in residential, hospitality, retail, and services. In addition, the metro extension will also give a boost to regional economic growth by creating job opportunities tied to improved infrastructure.

This extension will be a transformative step toward better urban mobility and regional integration. The approved proposal will be sent to the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs for the issuance of the final Gazette Notification.

Delhi University announces Spot Round-I for UG admissions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi University on Wednesday announced the schedule for spot admission Round-I for undergraduate programmes under the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS) 2026-27, along with schedules for other undergraduate categories, BTech and post-graduate programmes.

The university said candidates who applied for CSAS (UG)-2026 but were not admitted to any college as on August 22 will be eligible to participate in the spot admission Round-I.

Vacant seats for the spot round will be displayed on August 23, following which the eligible candidates can apply through their dashboards till 11.59 pm on August 24. The allocated seats will be declared thereafter, which the candidates will have to accept between August 25 and August 27.



Colleges will verify and approve the applications till 4.59 pm on August 28, while the last date for payment of admission fees is August 29.

The university said candidates participating in the spot round will have to compulsorily take admission to the seat allocated to them. There will be no option of upgrade or withdrawal during the spot admission rounds, and the seat allocated in a particular spot round will be final.

The schedule also includes the upgrade Round-II and Round-II for children/widows of personnel of the armed forces

(CW), ECA, sports and performance-based programmes, including music, bachelor of fine arts (BFA) and physical education, health education and sports (PE, HE&S).

Candidates will get an upgrade and preference-reordering window on August 16 and 17, while declarations and acceptance of allocations for these categories will follow as per the university's schedule.

For BTech programmes, the university has announced a mid-entry window for fresh candidates from August 13 till 4.59 pm on August 14.

Spot admission Round-II will be declared on August 17, with candidates required to accept allocated seats between August 17 and August 19. Round-II allocations under the CW and ward quotas will be declared on August 18, with candidates required to accept the allotted seats by 4.59 pm on August 19.

Preity Zinta gets emotional at Hindu College, says she is proud to be Indian

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

The auditorium at Hindu College was full before she arrived. Students had been waiting since morning, some with phones already raised, ready. When Preity Zinta walked in, the room did what rooms full of young people do when someone from another world enters theirs. It got loud. But what happened after the noise settled was something quieter and more unexpected. She got emotional. And so, a little did they. Zinta was at the University of Delhi on Wednesday to speak about Batwara 1947, the partition film directed by Raj Kumar Santoshi that releases on August 14, one day before Independence Day.

She spoke about the film, about the story it tells, and about partition being a chapter of history that Indian cinema has largely avoided turning into mainstream drama. But then she said something that had nothing to do with the film's promotions.

She said she is proud to be born in India. She said the



kind of opportunity and freedom this country gives is immense. She said she can be everything here. She can be an actor and an entrepreneur. She said that this, the ability to be everything at once, is possible in this country. The students listened to this from a woman who actually did both, who built a career in films and then built a business in cricket, and who has lived enough of her life outside India to know what the comparison looks like.

Batwara 1947 is Raj Kumar Santoshi's adaptation of Asghar Wajahat's play about the partition's human cost,

shaped around a character named Sikandar Mirza, played by Sunny Deol, a man who leaves his home in Lucknow to settle in Lahore as violence grips the subcontinent. At an allocated mansion in Lahore, he finds an old Hindu woman still living inside and vows to protect her from extremists. Santoshi has said Mirza is the most courageous character he has written. The film also stars Shabana Azmi, Karan Deol, Ali Fazal, and Abhimanyu Singh.

The reunion between Santoshi and Sunny Deol, who previously made Ghayal in 1990, Damini in 1993, and Ghatak in 1996, has been nearly three decades in the making. Santoshi had narrated the script to Sunny as early as 2010. Producers took years to come around. It was Gadar 2's success that finally opened the door. Sunny has said that before Gadar 2, the industry did not believe the two of them were commercially sellable.

Zinta, speaking to students and press on Wednesday, said the film has unique elements. There are not many partition-based stories made

in Indian cinema, she said, and this one has something worth telling. She urged the audience to watch it. "Through your platform, we would like to encourage audiences to watch it because it is

a wonderful and meaningful film. It is a movie that has a strong message and is worth watching by all," she said.

The film releases on August 14, the day before India turns 79.

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STATEMENT OF UN-AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS (STANDALONE AND CONSOLIDATED) FOR THE QUARTER ENDED JUNE 30, 2026

The Board of Directors of the Company, at its meeting held on August 12, 2026 has approved the Un-audited Financial Results for the quarter ended June 30, 2026.

The aforesaid Financial Results along with the Limited Review Report have been uploaded on the Company's website and websites of BSE and NSE. The same is available at <https://irctc.com/assets/images/2/OutcomeBMHeld12August2026.pdf> and can be accessed by scanning the QR code.

For & on behalf of the Board of Directors
Sd/-
Rahul Himailan
Chairman & Managing Director
DIN: 10393348

Place : New Delhi
Dated : 12 August, 2026

Note: The above intimation is in accordance with Regulation 33 read with Regulation 47 (1) of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015.

IRCTC Ltd., 4th Floor, Tower-D, World Trade Centre, Nauroji Nagar, New Delhi-110029 Tel. 011-35464045

नरेन्द्र मोदी
 प्रधानमंत्री

सत्यमेव जयते
दिल्ली सरकार

DIRECTORATE OF EDUCATION
 GOVERNMENT OF NCT OF DELHI

रेखा गुप्ता
 मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

दिल्ली सरकार द्वारा 1300 से अधिक नवनि्युक्त शिक्षकों का

नियुक्ति पत्र वितरण समारोह

मुख्य अतिथि

श्रीमती रेखा गुप्ता

माननीय मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

विशिष्ट अतिथि

श्री आशीष सूद

माननीय शिक्षा मंत्री, दिल्ली सरकार



गुरुवार, 13 अगस्त 2026



सुबह 10:00 बजे



भारत मंडपम, नई दिल्ली

IN FOCUS



People take part in the Tiranga Yatra, near India Gate in New Delhi on Wednesday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

Madhya Pradesh has joined Maharashtra, Gujarat and Chhattisgarh in banning the production, sale and use of analogue paneer in the state. Chief Minister Dr Mohan Yadav issued directions to this effect on Wednesday during a meeting with officials of the Food and Civil Supplies Department before leaving for Gujarat.

He said the state would promote natural milk production and encourage the preparation of paneer from milk rather than substitutes.

“Analogue paneer is being banned in Madhya Pradesh, as has been done by other states. We will increase milk production naturally and make paneer naturally from milk,” the Chief Minister said. Analogue paneer is prepared as a cheaper alterna-



tive to traditional milk-based paneer. It is made using ingredients such as vegetable fats, starch and other substances, either in place of milk or along with milk. Its lower cost has contributed to a sharp increase in its consumption in the market. The daily inflow and sale of analogue paneer in

Madhya Pradesh is estimated at around 300 to 400 quintals. At this rate, approximately 9,000 to 12,000 quintals, or 900 to 1,200 tonnes, of analogue paneer is estimated to be consumed in the state every month.

The large-scale sale of the product has prompted the state government to take

stricter action.

The issue has also drawn the attention of the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC). The commission has expressed concern over the sale of analogue paneer and has decided to write to Madhya Pradesh and other states seeking information about

the sale of such products and their potential impact on public health.

NHRC member Priyank Kanoongo said analogue paneer is dangerous and that the commission is seeking an explanation from the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) on why such products are being permitted for sale.

Kanoongo questioned whether simply putting a health warning on a product would prevent it from causing harm, drawing a comparison with cigarette warnings. He said that since governments in three states had already taken a strong decision on the issue, other states should also consider similar action.

He also pointed out that analogue paneer may not always be detected through a test based only on aerobic starch, suggesting that the

testing mechanism needs to be strengthened.

Following the Chief Minister's directions, the Food Safety Department has started taking action against suspected violations. On Wednesday, a team from the department inspected Umapati Industries in Palda, where low-fat paneer was being produced and packed.

During the inspection, officials found several deficiencies related to food safety standards. The team subsequently seized 450 kg of paneer from the premises.

The state government's decision is expected to bring greater scrutiny to the production, supply and sale of paneer substitutes across Madhya Pradesh, particularly in view of the significant quantities of analogue paneer estimated to be entering and being sold in the state's markets.

Patriotic songs and tricolour replace Maoist war cries, diktats in Bastar region

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Narayanpur (Chhattisgarh)

Hundreds of motorbikes carrying national flags sped through Bastar, long considered a hotbed of banned Maoist cadres, as the three-day Bastar Tiranga Yatra commenced, signalling a transformation towards peace and security across the region.

The rally was flagged off on Wednesday from the Higher Secondary School ground in Narayanpur district by Deputy Chief Minister Vijay Sharma and Forest Minister Kedar Kashyap, who both joined the procession on motorcycles. Over 200 motorbikes, driven by local residents and community representatives, set off amidst patriotic slogans to cover routes historically dominated by Maoist insurgency.

The convoy is scheduled to conclude its journey at the Karregutta hills in Bijapur district, situated near the



Telangana border. The location holds strategic significance as the site of a 21-day joint operation by central and state security forces in April and May last year, which resulted in the deaths of at least 31 Naxals.

Sharma said the yatra would pass through areas where Maoist violence had once affected people's lives and convey to the country and the world that "Maoism has now ended in these areas". Narayanpur was chosen as the starting point as the district had remained among the most severely Naxal-affected areas for a long period, he said.

PM asks Gen Z to read more

The PM was speaking at the launch of former president Ram Nath Kovind's autobiography *Triumph of the Indian Republic: My Life, My Struggles*. PM Modi said Kovind's life showed how determination could help a person overcome adversity and rise to the highest constitutional office. Highlighting Kovind's continuing public engagement, PM Modi said the former president had not rested after demitting office and was working on the "One Nation, One Election" initiative, which could "open a new chapter in Indian democracy". Kovind's efforts on the issue were part of his continued contribution to strengthening Indian democracy.

The PM said Kovind's autobiography would become a "heritage for Indian democracy" and the new generation has much to learn from it. "We need many more young people who would be like Kovind in future; people who are not defeated by circumstances, but possess the determination to overcome every challenge. They will pave the way for a self-reliant India, and this autobiography will serve as a source of inspiration for the youth," Modi said.

He said the title of the book was apt because while Kovind's life and struggles were personal, "the victories of those struggles belong to the Indian democracy".

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, who was present at the book launch, described Kovind as a "living sketch" of determination and lauded him for strengthening India's diplomatic relations.

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and several Union ministers attended the event.

Shah offers debate, Rahul says resign

"I want to request you to kindly consult the Opposition. With everyone's consent, allocate as much time needed for the debate. I will sit through the entire discussion and respond to all questions from the opposition during the debate," Shah said. Rahul turned down the proposal and asserted that the youth want to know who ordered that "protesting students be shot" at with pellet guns. He said the Opposition was not interested in listening to Shah's imagination and lecture in Parliament. If Shah ordered that students be shot at, he is culpable, and if he did not, he is incompetent, Gandhi said. "In both the cases he should resign," the LoP said.

When the Lok Sabha reassembled at 3 pm after two adjournments on Wednesday, the Opposition resorted to protests. Amid the turmoil, Union Minister for Parliamentary Affairs, Kiren Rijiju announced in the House that the Government was ready to start a debate immediately on the student protest, and Shah had already written to the speaker. He said the Opposition should not run away from the debate when the home minister was ready to answer all their questions.

Rijiju addressed a hurriedly convened Press conference after the Lok Sabha was adjourned for the

MP bans production and sale of analogue paneer

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

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stricter action.

The issue has also drawn the attention of the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC). The commission has expressed concern over the sale of analogue paneer and has decided to write to Madhya Pradesh and other states seeking information about

Shiv Sena row: Will have to first see if there was split in party: SC



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday said that it will have to first see whether there had been a split in the Shiv Sena as such a division may originate in the legislature party and the fissure can percolate into the organisation and the primary membership.

The observations were made by a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymlaya Bagchi and V

Mohana during the final hearing on the pleas by the Uddhav Thackeray faction to the Election Commission's decision recognising the Eknath Shinde-led faction as the original Shiv Sena and allotting it the party's name and the "bow and arrow" symbol.

During the hearing on the fourth day, Justice Bagchi said "First, we have to see whether there is a split. A split may originate in the legislature party, but the fissure can percolate into the organisation and the primary membership."



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Indore

Rape survivors, whose pregnancies are up to 24 weeks old, do not require court approval to seek a legal termination, the Madhya Pradesh High Court has said, citing a judicial precedent.

Justice Sandeep N Bhatt of the Indore bench made the observation while dismissing a writ petition filed by the father of a 16-year-old rape survivor and directed the Commissioner of the State Health Department to disseminate the division bench's order to all concerned hospitals, especially those run by government, so that they can take care of such situations in the future.

The minor had approached the court seeking authorisation to terminate an 18-week pregnancy resulting from sexual assault, citing severe mental trauma. The single-judge

bench issued the order on Tuesday. The high court cited a February 20, 2025, judgment by the HC's Jabalpur bench which had clarified that under the Medical Termination of Pregnancy (MTP) Act, 1971, survivors of sexual assault, rape, or incest do not need to institute court proceedings under Article 226 of the Constitution to undergo an abortion.

Talking to media, the petitioner's lawyer, Ashish Choubey, said the minor

rape victim had filed a petition in the high court through her father seeking appropriate directions for legal termination of the unwanted pregnancy.

He said that the girl does not want to continue the pregnancy resulting from the rape as she was under immense mental distress.

The high court had said in the 2025 judgment that in case of survivors of sexual assault or rape or incest, the pregnancy up to 20 weeks may be terminated by a reg-

FROM PAGE - 1

and was appointed Tata Sons chairman in 2017, succeeding Ratan Tata's interim tenure after Cyrus Mistry's ouster. He was the first non-Parsi chairman of Tata Sons and was credited with bringing stability to the group after the bruising 2016 boardroom battle.

Under him, the group expanded aggressively into aviation, electronics, semiconductors, batteries and digital commerce while strengthening its traditional technology, automotive and steel businesses. Tatas acquired Air India from the government in 2022 and subsequently consolidated Air India, Vistara, Air India Express and AIX Connect into a major airline operation.

The scale-up has been reflected in the group's financial footprint. Tata companies reported aggregate revenue of more than \$180 billion in 2024-25, employed more than one million people, and the group's 26 listed companies had a combined market capitalisation of more than \$328 billion as of March 31, 2025.

PAN-PAN call before Delhi adds new clue...

In the case of AI2379, investigators are expected to establish why the urgency call was made only during the latter part of the flight if the aircraft had experienced a significant altitude change earlier.

The recorded communication with the ATC could also help establish what the pilots told controllers about the altitude loss, passenger injuries, aircraft systems and any other operational concerns. ATC radio recordings, along with the aircraft's cockpit voice recorder and flight-data recorder, are expected to provide investigators with a more complete chronology. The precise wording of the transmission will be important. The available account does not, by itself, establish that the pilot intentionally withheld information from ATC or that the cockpit crew had a complete assessment of the situation at the time of the call.

The number of people injured in the incident has varied between preliminary accounts. Later reports have put the figure at 24 passengers and crew members, while earlier figures cited by the airline were lower. Investigators are therefore expected to rely on hospital and medical records, airport documentation and other official material to establish the final number and nature of the injuries. Information cited in reports has referred to warnings involving hydraulic systems, flight controls and other aircraft components, including low-pressure indications and low-fluid warnings in two hydraulic reservoirs.

There have also been reports of autopilot disconnects and indications concerning elevator-control systems. However, the presence of individual warnings does not automatically establish that the aircraft suffered a complete hydraulic or flight-control failure. The investigation will have to determine whether the indications were connected to the altitude loss and whether any technical malfunction contributed to the episode.

The Airbus A320 family relies on multiple hydraulic systems to provide redundancy for several critical functions, including flight controls, landing gear and braking.

Another issue under discussion is the decision to continue to Delhi rather than divert to the nearest suitable airport. Captain Sam Thomas, President of the Airline Pilots Association of India (ALPA India), said the decision to divert depends on the overall circumstances and is not determined solely by the captain. "MAYDAY is used for grave or impending danger, such as when an aircraft is not under control, has a structural issue or fire. If the aircraft is flyable but there is another urgent issue, such as a medical emergency, PAN-PAN is the correct call," Thomas said.

"We believe the captain made the right decision to come to Delhi, which offered better logistical support for the injured passengers," he said. He said the decision regarding the destination airport is taken after considering inputs from the co-pilot, cabin crew and the airline.

The Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau has taken custody of the aircraft's Flight Data Recorder and Cockpit Voice Recorder as part of the probe. Airbus and French aviation investigation authorities are also assisting with the technical examination. The cockpit crew has also faced scrutiny over reports concerning the captain's post-flight drug screening. Reports have said an initial screening produced a positive result and that subsequent confirmatory testing also indicated marijuana use. Both pilots were reportedly removed from flying duties pending the inquiry.

Separate reports have raised questions about the captain's sleep, medication and overall fitness for duty. Investigators will have to establish the relevance, if any, of these factors to the incident rather than treating them as evidence of causation.

LG approves Master Plan for Delhi 2047

The plan will now be sent to the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs for final approval and subsequent notification. The first master plan for Delhi was promulgated in 1962 under the Delhi Development Act of 1957, followed by the master plans of 2001 and 2021, the last of which was also delayed and eventually notified in 2007.

A master plan is a long-term planning document that is supposed to provide a conceptual layout to guide a city's future growth and development. It includes analysis, recommendations and proposals covering a city's population, economy, housing, transportation, community facilities and land use.

With Delhi's population projected to grow significantly by 2047, the Master Plan adopts an integrated approach towards housing, economic growth, mobility, environmental sustainability, infrastructure, heritage conservation, urban regeneration and citizen-centric governance.

The new plan is expected to move the needle forward on some of Delhi's most contested urban questions, including the land pooling policy meant to unlock large tracts of Outer Delhi for planned development; the Green Development Area (GDA) policy; and the fate of unauthorised colonies in the Yamuna's O-Zone, an ecologically sensitive floodplain housing over five lakh

people, which the Delhi High Court ruled in May cannot legally have residential colonies.

Apart from this, important decisions included, Policy for Reconstruction and Redevelopment of Old DDA-built Two-Storey Units, and Change of Land Use for development of Metro Depot of Rithala-Kundli Corridor in Narela Sub-City for expansion of metro corridor. Amendments to Unified Building Bye-Laws (UBBL)-2016 were also approved to reduce compliance burden and improve Ease of Doing Business.

Delhi Police goes kuchu-puchu to...

Delhi Police has not been treating this lightly despite the playful post. The Crime Branch recently seized more than 1,300 rolls of Chinese manjha in an enforcement operation. Central Delhi Police recovered around 120 rolls separately. The banned string is not difficult to find in the capital's kite markets, which means the bans have not been followed by the kind of enforcement that makes bans meaningful. The social media post and the seizures are two ends of the same policy problem: how do you make people understand that a thing they associate with festivity is also capable of killing a child on her way to buy vegetables with her father.

The kuchu puchu post is one answer to that. Not the entire answer. Not even most of the answer. But in a city where public attention is fought for in three-second windows, a police force that can make you smile before it makes you think has at least solved the first half of the problem. The second half is the string still for sale around the corner.

FCRA Bill sent to JPC for review

The Opposition has been claiming that the Bill will target NGOs and minority institutions, while the Government has rubbishised the charge. Congress leader KC Venugopal and SP chief Akhilesh Yadav dubbed the bill "anti-minority" and demanded its withdrawal. "The Bill is against NGOs and minority institutions who are doing good work," Venugopal said. He was joined by Yadav, who said: "The entire Opposition is against the Bill and it must be withdrawn." The Opposition also questioned the absence of Home Minister Amit Shah, as the resolution on sending the FCRA Bill to the JPC was earlier listed against his name in the Supplementary List of Business of the Lok Sabha.

Amid mounting criticism, the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) clarified on July 22 that the designated authority would manage only assets created from foreign contributions, and only after an organisation's registration has lawfully ceased. As Minister Rai rose to move the resolution to send the Bill to JPC, the Opposition benches opposed it vehemently. Responding to the Opposition's charge, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said the Opposition should welcome the move to send the bill to the JPC.

You have changed: Modi, Kharge exchange banter at social event

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

High temperatures in the current monsoon session of Parliament notwithstanding, bonhomie between political opponents was on display at a social event. Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge exchanged banter, with the former commenting, “*Aap badal gaye ho* (you have changed)” in response to the latter saying, “I am just the same as always.”

The friendly chat took place at the wedding reception of NCP (SP) MP Supriya Sule's daughter in New Delhi on Monday. Who's who of politics were present at the gathering. A video has now emerged showing Kharge and Modi engaging in a light-hearted conversation.

Political rivalry took a backseat; the Prime Minister, Congress chief and the Gandhi siblings shared the same frame at the reception. Rare as the sight was, a video



of the leaders sharing a light-hearted exchange has now gone viral on social media.

The interaction began with Modi asking Priyanka Gandhi Vadra about how she was doing. “How is Priyanka doing?” he can be heard asking in the clip. “I am doing well, sir! How are you?” Priyanka, who is not visible in the video, replies.

To this, the Prime Minister said, “I am just the same as always”. Modi's reply drew a chuckle from the Congress president who was standing nearby. “*Bhai saab, aap thoda*

badal gaye saab (Brother, you have changed a bit),” Kharge was heard telling PM Modi. He, however, did not elaborate on his remark.

The Prime Minister appeared amused by Kharge's quip. “Oh really?” he responded before both sides broke into laughter. Rahul Gandhi is also seen in the frame smiling at the interaction between the two leaders.

The light-hearted exchange happened as political leaders from across the spectrum attended the wedding reception of Supriya Sule's daugh-

ter Revati at Sharad Pawar's 6, Janpath, residence in New Delhi. Another photo of PM Modi and Sharad Pawar engaged in an intense discussion at the wedding reception also grabbed attention, coming amid speculation of NCP(SP) warming up to the BJP. However, Sule has previously clarified that the party's recent engagements with PM Modi were strictly regarding issues related to Maharashtra.

The high-profile gathering came as Parliament witnessed a logjam amid protests by the Congress over the police crackdown on students during their ‘Sansad Chalo’ march on July 20.

The high-profile reception at 6 Janpath in Delhi celebrated Revati Sule's marriage to Nagpur-based industrialist Sarang Lakhani. The couple married in Mumbai in June, with the Delhi gathering marking a grand reception.

The reception witnessed a galaxy of political stars who turned up to bless the newlyweds.

West Bengal passes delimitation laws for Kolkata, Howrah

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

The Bengal Assembly, through a special one-day session on Wednesday, passed two civic delimitation amendment bills aimed at delimiting the civic areas under the Kolkata Municipal Corporation and Howrah Municipal Corporation.

The first bill is the Howrah Municipal Corporation (Amendment) Bill, 2026, and the second one is the Kolkata Municipal Corporation (Amendment) Bill, 2026.

Following the gubernatorial assent, the number of wards under Kolkata Municipal Corporation would go up from 144 to 209, whereas the number of civic wards in Howrah would go up to 68 from the existing 50. Apart from this, the Bally municipal area would be separated from Howrah Corporation.

The on-ground delimitation exercise would be taken up by the State Election Commission in cooperation with the Kolkata district administrative authorities, Chief Minister Suwendu



West Bengal Legislative Assembly

Adhikari said, referring to a question raised by senior opposition MLA and former Mayor Firhad Hakim.

“It seems that the honourable member is ill-informed about the delimitation exercise... presently only the numbers of the two municipal corporations have been fixed whereas actual delimitation exercise will take place subsequently... The State Election Commission will mark the boundaries of the wards... based on the number of voters, population and other details,” the Chief Minister said, referring to Hakim's

apprehensions of a “politically motivated delimitation” targeting certain specific wards or communities.

Hakim, however, said that he was not opposed to the delimitation of the wards in principle “but it should be made clear on what policy or criteria the entire process is being carried out.”

The Chief Minister said that apart from the SEC, the Land and Land Reforms Department and officials responsible for the administration of Kolkata district would be involved in the process before a draft notification was issued.

SIA raids 9 locations in 1990 Kashmiri Pandit murder probe

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

Thirty-six years after the merciless killing of renowned Kashmiri Pandit scholar and poet, Sarwanand Koul ‘Premi’ and his son Virender Koul, the Jammu and Kashmir State Investigation Agency on Wednesday conducted raids across nine locations in Baramulla, Rajouri and Jammu to gather vital evidence against the perpetrators behind the targeted killing at the peak of militancy in April 1990.

The searches were carried out after obtaining search warrants from the competent court in connection with FIR No. 45/1990 registered at Police Station Dooru, relating to the killing of Premi and his 27-year-old son.

According to official sources, searches were conducted across 6 locations in Rajouri, 2 in Jammu and 1 in Baramulla.

After filing a 737-page chargesheet in the abduction, torture and brutal killing of Sarla Bhat, a staff nurse at Sher-i-Kashmir Institute of Medical Sciences (SKIMS), Srinagar, the SIA has launched a fresh probe to identify the killers and key conspirators behind the gruesome murder of Premi and his son.

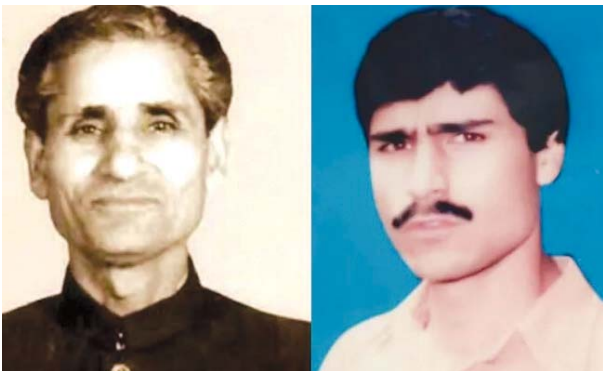
Sarla Bhat was killed by JKLF terrorists on 18 April 1990. Eleven days later, three terrorists stormed the residence of a social activist and freedom fighter of the Quit India Movement, Sarwanand Koul, in Anantnag and

abducted him on the night of April 29-30, 1990. The terrorists allegedly looted valuables and cash and ordered him to accompany them to their commander. His younger son, Virender Koul, insisted on going with his father, reportedly out of concern for his safety.

On May 1, 1990, the family recovered the mutilated dead bodies of their head of the family and a young son. Eyewitness and media reports claimed that part of Premi's forehead, where he used to apply sandalwood, was cruelly pierced by a sharp weapon and the skin was peeled off. The entire body bore the marks of cigarette burns. The limbs were found broken, and the eyes of both the father and the son were gouged out. They were later hanged and, to be doubly sure, shot dead too.

Sarwanand Koul ‘Premi’ was a respected school headmaster from Soaf Shali in Kokernag. A celebrated literary figure, he authored and translated more than three dozen works. Among his notable literary contributions were translations of Rabindranath Tagore's Gitanjali into Kashmiri, the Bhagavad Gita into Urdu and the Ramayana into Kashmiri.

At the peak of militancy, when terrorists started targeted killings of members belonging to the minority community, Premi had decided to stay put in the Valley, believing that the goodwill and personal rela-



Sarwanand Koul ‘Premi’ and his son Virender Koul

tionships he had built across communities would protect him. His merciless killing became one of the most chilling episodes associated with the targeting of Kashmiri Pandits in the valley and triggered a mass exodus of hapless families.

Official sources told The Pioneer that the SIA team investigating the double murder case of Sarwanand Koul and his son is on the job to collect evidence and identify individuals who may have participated in, facilitated or assisted the perpetrators of the 1990 crime.

Without identifying the dreaded terrorist behind the killing of Sarwanand Koul, a senior officer revealed that the terrorists behind the gruesome murder had been eliminated long ago. The raids were conducted at the residences of close relatives and their associates.

Speaking to The Pioneer over the telephone, Rajinder Koul, the elder son of

Sarwanand Premi, said this is the struggle for the last 36 years, which I have been personally pursuing not only with the government of Jammu and Kashmir but also with the Union Government. The promises the government made to us were broken. Not a single promise of assurance given to us at that time was kept. “When we left Kashmir after the killing of my father and brother, we stayed in Jammu for a very brief time period and then went to Delhi after completing the rituals. There was no communication with the government”. He said my struggle dates back to 1991. When we started pursuing our matters with the Jammu and Kashmir government. “Our local temple was demolished by the mob in 1992, our two houses in our native village were burnt down in 1998, and an FIR was also registered”. He said the State Human Rights Commission was approached; they deliv-

ered a decision after almost five years. “A comprehensive and considered judgment was given by the two-member bench of the commission. The recommendations were not translated into action by the government. Many meetings were held in the state government. Nothing conclusive happened. Then we moved to the National Human Rights Commission. The NHRC also made certain recommendations. They heard me for four or five long years. They said, ‘Nothing doing’. The NHRC has no business to intervene in our matter. We don't have the manpower to look into all this. The files have gathered dust, and we cannot dig out the old record. Koul claimed they requested the NHRC to keep this matter in abeyance. I have no hesitation in saying that my family has been a victim of bureaucracy, Koul said. According to him, on 18 April 2024, the NHRC delivered a final judgment in the matter. They said the whole case should be looked into afresh purely on a humanitarian angle, not from any other angle, because they could understand that this was political victimisation.

Koul also welcomed the raids, hoping that all cases would be handled this way.

Rajender further demanded justice for everyone. “I appeal to the State Government that all the cases should be handed over to the SIA for expeditious and effective investigation.

Opposition slams Suwendu’s move for anti-conversion law in West Bengal

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

The Opposition parties have questioned the “intention behind” Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari's announcement that his Government was planning to bring legislation to prevent forced conversions in tandem with the proposed Uniform Civil Code.

While senior pro-Mamata Banerjee Trinamool Congress leader Kunal Ghosh said that such laws were only a “diversionary tactic to hide the Government's failure to implement the social programmes that were promised before the elections,” CPI(M) central committee member and former MP Sujan Chakrabarty said “both the proposed UCC and anti-conversion laws are a part of the BJP's divisive agenda... but that will not succeed in a State like



TMC leader Kunal Ghosh

Bengal... here you have to work and win by ideological appeal and nothing else because the people are politically conscious.”

Adhikari had on Tuesday told reporters at Bankura that his Government was planning to introduce a bill to prevent forced religious conversions in the state. Informing that the Uniform

Civil Code would be implemented in the state shortly, he said that the draft bill in this regard has already been prepared and was being scrutinised by an expert committee.

The State Government

had formed a nine-member high-level committee led by former Supreme Court judge Justice Ranjana Prakash Desai to examine the draft UCC law.

Alleging that funds that were coming to Bengal from abroad in the name of setting up religious institutions were in fact being used for religious conversions, Adhikari said that his government was planning a new law to stall such activities.

He also said that a new and strict law would be brought on transfer of property through transaction of lands.

“A strict law is also in the offing to control the sale and purchase of lands,” he said, apparently against the backdrop of reports of large swathes of lands belonging to a particular community getting transferred to another community in some minority dominated districts or areas along the international borders.

Maharashtra ATS busts inter-state methamphetamine network

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ Mumbai/New Delhi

Maharashtra's Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) seized 4.738 kg of methamphetamine worth Rs 9.4 crore in an inter-state operation that started in Bhandra East and ended at a hidden factory in Greater Noida. Police arrested one Israeli man and two foreign women, and sealed the manufacturing unit.

On Tuesday, the ATS Kalachowki unit got a tip that a courier would be near Amber Hotel. Officers set up a trap on Anant Kanherekar Marg, near Bhandra Court, and caught the suspect. They found 2,050 grams of the drug, worth Rs 4 crore. He was arrested under the NDPS Act. During questioning, he admitted he bought the drugs from a factory in Greater Noida to sell in Mumbai.

An ATS team, with help from local Uttar Pradesh police, raided the site the same day. Officers seized another 2,688 grams of the drug, worth Rs 5.4 crore, along with materials used for making it, and shut down the premises. Nawal Bajaj, Additional Director General of Police, ATS Maharashtra, confirmed both seizures and the three arrests.

During questioning, the arrested man said he bought the drugs from a factory in Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh, to sell in Mumbai. The ATS, with help from local police, raided the factory and found another 2,688 grams of methamphetamine worth Rs 5.4 crore, along with materials used for making the drug. The factory was sealed. In total, officers seized 4.738 kg



of methamphetamine, valued at about Rs 9.4 crore.

ATS is looking for women who are co-accused and are still missing, showing that the investigation is still in its early stages. This operation shows how synthetic drug networks are spreading across state borders. Methamphetamine, also known as crystal meth, is a growing concern for law enforcement because it is valuable and easy to produce in small units.

Greater Noida has been involved in several past cases with foreign nationals and secret drug facilities, partly because it is well connected to the National Capital Region. Officials said the ATS is now looking into where the raw materials came from, how the drugs were transported to Mumbai, and the exact roles of those arrested and any other people involved.

The involvement of foreign nationals has prompted investigators to look into possible transnational links. Because foreign nationals are involved, investigators are now checking for possible international connections. They are

also trying to find out if the network reached other cities or distribution channels in Maharashtra. The NDPS Act has strict penalties for cases involving large amounts of these drugs. Authorities said sealing the Greater Noida factory was a clear blow to the supply chain. Still, they warned that synthetic drug operations often change locations quickly. They challenged traditional narcotics in both volume and profitability. The agency continues to work with counterparts in Uttar Pradesh to map the full extent of the racket.

Additional arrests and recoveries cannot be ruled out as custodial questioning and forensic examination of the seized materials progress. This case shows why police from different states need to work together to fight modern drug syndicates that take advantage of gaps between jurisdictions. Law enforcement agencies across India have increased their efforts against synthetic drugs because of growing worries about addiction and social problems, officials said.

34-point questionnaire: Inside Ram temple’s search for CEO

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Ayodhya

The application process for Ayodhya Ram Mandir's first full-time CEO was much more thorough than usual. The 18 shortlisted candidates for the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust had to fill out a detailed 34-point online questionnaire about their personal background, work experience, and religious beliefs.

The form sought full name and date of birth. The form asked for basic details like full name, date of birth, age, address, contact information, and email. Candidates also had to share their language skills in Hindi and English, highest education level, current or past job status, and details about their employer. It included questions about years of management or administrative experience, the sector they worked in, and the size of teams they managed. Organised or supervised events, including estimated attendance, duration, year, event name and the candidate's role, vital for handling large religious gatherings.

Applicants disclosed any prior association with religious institutions, monasteries, social organisations or temples, along with duration and scale. A key query asked whether the candidate considered themselves a “staunch Hindu,” “true Hindu” or “hardline Hindu,” versus simply a believer, plus details of links to Hindu religious institutions. The form also required a vision statement for the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra, a proposed work plan and suggestions for temple management, plus names, positions and contacts of



at least two reputable references for verification of professional, social or religious experience.

The form also collected family and personal information. During the closed-door interviews, which lasted 40 to 50 minutes or more, the three-member panel asked more questions about personal and religious practices. Some of the reported questions were: “Are you a staunch Hindu?” “Do you eat non-vegetarian food?” “Are you a pure vegetarian?” “Do you keep a shikha (tuft of hair)?” “Do you wear a janeu (sacred thread)?” “Do you consume alcohol or are you a teetotaler?”

Candidates were also questioned about their comfort with traditional Hindu attire, their faith in Lord Ram, and their understanding of the temple's religious and social importance. The panel asked about their experience managing large crowds, family background, personal prefer-

ences, people skills, and their overall vision for running the temple's administration, finances, security, and daily operations.

These questions show that the Trust wants the CEO to be a practising Hindu between 50 and 70 years old, follow Hindu traditions, be a strict vegetarian and teetotaler, have at least 20 years of relevant experience, speak Hindi and English fluently, and live in Ayodhya. The job comes with a three-year initial term and involves managing the temple's daily administration, finances, legal matters, security, and operations.

The search for a full-time CEO began after allegations of embezzlement of temple donations came up in June 2026, leading to closer checks on financial management. Over 5,200 applications were received from all over India. After about 20 days of screening, which included the Google Form and some online meetings,

the panel shortlisted 18 candidates. Most of them are retired bureaucrats, former senior corporate executives, retired defence officers, or people with experience managing temples or religious trusts.

Interviews started on 11 August 2026 at the temple complex and continued for several days. The selection panel includes retired Supreme Court Justice Pramod Kohli, retired Lt Gen Vishnukant Chaturvedi, and Suresh Haware, former chairperson of the Shri Saibaba Sansthan Trust in Shirdi. The panel will recommend three candidates to the Trust, which is expected to decide at its meeting around 2 September 2026. The full list of the 18 shortlisted candidates has not been officially released, keeping the process confidential.

Only a few names have been shared by sources so far: former IPS officer Rajesh Kumar Pandey (sometimes called an encounter specialist and linked to Lucknow's Hanuman Mandir), Dinesh Chandra (former Jaunpur District Magistrate), Yogeshwar Ram Mishra (retired IAS officer and former Faizabad district magistrate), and Sameer Pandaya. On the first day of interviews, three former IAS officers, one former IPS officer, and four former military officers reportedly took part.

The detailed questionnaire and personal questions show that the Trust is looking for someone who is both professionally skilled and closely aligned with the spiritual values of the Ram Mandir. The person chosen will need to manage complex logistics, finances, and meet the expectations of millions of devotees.

States Focus



HAR GHAR TIRANGA A POWERFUL MOVEMENT NOW: NITIN NABIN

BJP president Nitin Nabin on Wednesday said that the 'Har Ghar Tiranga' initiative has transformed into a powerful public campaign with every section of society joining it to express national pride. Addressing a Tiranga Yatra at Kartavya Path here, Nabin said the Tricolour is a symbol of India's valour, sacrifice, unity and self-respect, as he called upon the youth to resolve to build a developed India by 2047.

Nabin urged people to participate in the Har Ghar Tiranga campaign on August 13, 14 and 15 by hoisting the national flag at their houses and taking selfies with it. "On 13, 14, and 15 August, for 3 days, the honour of Tricolour must be carried forward in every home. The Tricolour must be hoisted at our homes, selfies must be taken with it," he said. (PTI)



CHHATTISGARH GOVT COMMITTED TO FARMERS' WELFARE: CM SAI

Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai on Wednesday said his government was committed to the welfare and economic empowerment of farmers and has taken several measures to strengthen the agriculture sector.

Addressing a Hareli festival celebration at his official residence in Nava Raipur Atal Nagar, Sai said the agrarian festival reflects Chhattisgarh's deep bond with agriculture, nature and rural life.

Hareli, one of the major traditional festivals of Chhattisgarh, is celebrated on the new moon day (amavasya) of the month of Savan. Sai said the Centre and the state government have taken several important steps to strengthen farmers economically. (PTI)

BJP slams Rahul over police action on students in Ranchi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP criticised Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday over police action against protesting students in Ranchi, alleging that the Congress-led Opposition is unwilling to demand a CBI probe into alleged irregularities in Jharkhand's recruitment examinations.

The remarks came as ruling NDA MPs staged a protest on the Parliament premises over alleged police action against protesting students in Ranchi. They carried placards that read "Jharkhand me chhatron par lathicharge par Rahul Gandhi jawab do" and "Jharkhand me chhatron par hue anyay par Rahul Gandhi jawab do". Speaking to reporters in the Parliament House complex, Minister of State for Defence Sanjay Seth demanded CBI and ED probes into the alleged irregularities.

"You may issue as many Tughlaq-style orders as you



Minister of State for Defence Sanjay Seth

want, you may adopt as much of an authoritarian approach as you want, but a CBI inquiry and an ED inquiry will have to be conducted," Seth said.

He alleged that the entire scam in Jharkhand is worth around ₹400 crore.

"Whether it is through the TDPL, the JPSC or the JSSC, this is a scam worth hundreds of crores. The students are asking: who received a share of this money? Why are they not ordering a CBI investigation? Because people close to the chief minister and people associated with senior

Congress leaders are caught up in this web.

"That is why, out of sheer obstinacy, they are not ordering a CBI investigation. They know that the JMM Government will be in jeopardy," Seth alleged.

The Congress is part of the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha-led Government in the State.

Seth slammed Gandhi over the issue, alleging that the Congress leader lacks the courage to demand a probe in Jharkhand.

Seth claimed that the Jharkhand agitation is different from political protests in Delhi and is being led by stu-

dents and youngsters.

"The Jharkhand movement is non-political. This is an agitation by students and youngsters. There is no politics behind it," he said.

"We are public representatives, so naturally we will raise our voice," Seth added.

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader alleged that electricity supply at the protest site is being cut off at night and claimed that police have removed a generator set arranged by the students at their own expense.

"Last night, the electricity supply was cut off. Early this morning, the students had arranged a generator with their own money to ensure electricity supply, but police also removed that generator. This shows an authoritarian approach, a Tughlaq-style order," he said.

BJP MP Nishikant Dubey hit out at Gandhi and Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge over the students' protest in Ranchi and questioned why the party is not demanding a CBI probe now.

Opposition protests over Ram temple funds, police action against students



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Opposition MPs, including Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and party general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, held a protest in the Parliament House Complex on Wednesday over the alleged theft of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya and "police excesses" on student protesters last month.

They also demanded that Home Minister Amit Shah come to Parliament and make a statement on the

alleged police excesses on students during their July 20 Parliament march over the NEET paper leak issue.

Carrying placards, the MPs stood in front of the Makar Dwar of Parliament and raised slogans such as "Amit Shah sadan mein aao", "Amit Shah maafi maango" and "Chanda chor, kahan milenge, BJP ke daftar mein".

The Opposition MPs, mostly from the Congress, the Samajwadi Party and the TMC, lined up behind a big banner that read "Chanda kisne loota?" and raised slogans against the BJP.

Karnataka bans sale of tobacco products for one year

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The Department of Food Safety and Drug Administration has issued a notification prohibiting the sale and distribution of products containing tobacco and/or nicotine in Karnataka in the interest of public health, officials said on Wednesday.

The notification, dated August 10, 2026, will remain in force across the State for one year from the date of its issuance, they said.

The Food Safety Division of the Department of Food Safety and Drug Administration, Health and Family Welfare Department, Government of Karnataka, is undertaking stringent enforcement measures against products containing tobacco and/or nicotine, officials said.

Special inspection and enforcement operations are being conducted under the leadership of Food Safety Officers, targeting the manufacture, storage, transportation, distribution and sale of



gutkha, pan masala and other prohibited products containing tobacco and/or nicotine, they said.

"In exercise of the powers conferred under Section 30(2)(a) of the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006 and Regulation 2.3.4 of the Food Safety and Standards (Prohibition and Restrictions on Sales) Regulations, 2011, the Department of Food Safety and Drugs Administration has issued a Government Notification dated 10-08-2026," Srinivas K, Commissioner, Department of Food Safety

and Drugs Administration, said in a statement.

The notification prohibits the sale and distribution of products containing tobacco and nicotine in Karnataka in the interest of public health, he said.

The department has appealed to the public to inform the concerned authorities if they come across the manufacture, sale or distribution of prohibited tobacco and nicotine products and to extend their cooperation in building a healthy and addiction-free Karnataka.

Assam needs over ₹1,000 crore for flood relief: Himanta

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Wednesday said more than ₹1,000 crore may be required for repairing damaged properties and rehabilitating people affected by the latest wave of floods in the State.

Addressing a press conference in Guwahati, Sarma said Prime Minister Narendra Modi has assured full assistance from the Centre in the rehabilitation process.

"To give permanent relief, a rapid relief assessment drive was launched on August 9. As per an initial report, over 8,000 families have been assessed, and ₹150 crore damage has been estimated," he said.

The CM said the assessment will continue till August 30 and is expected to cover 50,000-60,000 families in Upper Assam districts severely affected by the latest floods.

"I believe there will be a spending of over ₹1,000 crore in damage repair and rehabilitation. The PM has assured



People gather on geo-tubes amid embankment repairs as part of the Assam Flood Response in Jorhat

that there is no issue in paying the affected families and asked us to do the assessment without any lapse," he said.

Sarma said the assessment would be conducted in multiple stages, with the final survey likely to be completed by September.

In several areas, including Nepalikhuti, Majgaon and Kamal Chapori, every house has suffered damage, he said.

"We are talking to the Centre and social scientists if a model housing scheme can be launched to rebuild

their houses. The Assam Government is looking to find a permanent solution to such floods," he added.

Acknowledging support from various groups in providing relief, Sarma said 72 YouTubers had raised funds for flood-affected people across the country.

"Many of them are already working on the ground and giving relief to the people. We are keeping a close watch on them whether they are spending the money for flood-affected areas or not," he said.

Sarma also released ₹11.3

crore for rebuilding 494 flood-damaged Anganwadi centres across Upper Assam.

"We want to restart these centres as soon as possible so that all services can be provided. Altogether 494 Anganwadi centres, which were damaged, will be rebuilt in this drive," he said.

Each centre will receive up to ₹2.5 lakh for restoration, he said.

The flood situation in Assam remained serious on Wednesday, with more than 1.12 lakh people affected across four districts amid a forecast of more rainfall.

Sarma said 64,891 flood-hit families had received ₹15,000 each as initial assistance, while another 31,212 families would receive the aid in the coming days.

"From August 20, ₹1.5 lakh each will be provided to affected Namghars, a place of worship for Vaishnavite followers, in flood-ravaged Sivasagar and Charaideo districts to rebuild the institutions. PWD has engaged 50 machines to clear the debris from roads," he said.

9 kids die in Balaghat tribal belt amid unexplained illness since June

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

Nine children have died since June 26 amid an unexplained illness reported in tribal areas of Balaghat district, with health authorities yet to determine the exact cause of the deaths.

A joint team of doctors from Jabalpur Medical College and Balaghat visited the affected areas to assess the situation. According to the medical team, affected children have shown symptoms including pneumonia, anaemia, dehydration, fever, itching, malaria and signs of kidney involvement.

Samples collected from the affected areas have been sent to a laboratory in Pune for testing. Health officials said the exact cause of the illness would be established only after the laboratory reports are received. The Health Department has not indicated when the reports are expected.

Civil Surgeon Dr Nilay Jain said all the affected children belonged to villages under Adori and Machhurda gram panchayats. Between June 26 and July 22, five children — siblings Lamanin and Sahil from Bondari, along with Pooja, Sachin and Preeti from Kundekasa — died. Two more deaths were reported later, with Arvind dying on August 6 and Mangli Markam on August 8.

Priyanka Dhurve was admitted to the



district hospital on August 9 and died on the night of August 11.

Doctors said the child was suffering from multiple health complications and that efforts were made to save her.

The continuing deaths have raised concern over the health situation in the tribal belt. Former Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Digvijaya Singh has written to Chief Minister Dr Mohan Yadav seeking an immediate state-level investigation into the deaths.

Singh has also demanded strict action against officials found responsible and financial assistance of ₹10 lakh each for the families of the deceased

children.

He further urged the government to airlift critically ill children to major hospitals in Nagpur, Raipur or Bhopal and bear the entire cost of their treatment. With the cause of the illness still undetermined, health authorities are awaiting the Pune laboratory reports to establish whether the deaths are linked to a common infection, disease or other medical factors.

The situation remains under close observation as medical teams continue to assess affected children and the overall health conditions in the area.

Abhishek urges LS speaker to decide on disqualification pleas against 20 rebel MPs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Trinamool Congress's (TMC) Lok Sabha leader Abhishek Banerjee said on Wednesday that he met Speaker Om Birla in the morning and sought an early decision on the party's pending disqualification petitions against 20 rebel MPs, warning that he would approach the Supreme Court if the speaker fails to act within the period required by law and judicial directions.

Banerjee said he first raised the issue with Birla in June, when the individual disqualification petitions were filed against the MPs, but nearly two months have passed without any satisfactory response.

"I had already raised this issue with the speaker in June, when individual disqualification petitions were moved against each of them. Nearly two months have



passed since then, but I have still not received any satisfactory response. Even today, I have been given essentially the same answer, while the petitions remain pending," he told reporters outside Parliament.

Banerjee said he is relying on the Supreme Court's directions regarding timely disposal of disqualification peti-

tions by the speaker. "If the speaker does not decide on these petitions within the period required by law and applicable judicial directions, I will be compelled to approach the Supreme Court and seek its intervention," he said.

Banerjee said he and other TMC MPs have repeatedly taken up the matter with Birla.

Hilsa returns to upper Ganga after decades

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The hilsa fish has been recorded in the middle and upper stretches of the Ganga after remaining virtually absent from these reaches for decades, in what officials called a significant milestone in river restoration and aquatic biodiversity conservation.

According to the Central Inland Fisheries Research Institute (ICAR-CIFRI), two hilsa weighing a combined 740 grams were found in the river near Markandey Mahadev Temple in Chandauli district of Uttar Pradesh, nearly three decades after the species had vanished from the upstream reaches.

Historically, hilsa migrated from the Bay of Bengal through the Ganga system



up to Varanasi, Prayagraj and beyond. However, the commissioning of the Farakka Barrage in 1975 severely disrupted its migratory pathway, causing a drastic decline in the middle and upper Ganga and affecting riverine fishing communities dependent on the species.

Recognising the ecological, nutritional, cultural and livelihood significance of the fish, ICAR-CIFRI, Barrackpore, and the National Mission for Clean Ganga (NMG) had initiated a long-term scientific programme for Hilsa restoration.

Russia appoints ex-CJI Chandrachud arbitrator in Ukraine dispute

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a rare honour for a former Chief Justice of India, Russia has appointed DY Chandrachud as an arbitrator in a high-stakes investment treaty dispute between Russia and Ukrainian-owned Oschadbank. He retired on November 10, 2024, after serving as the 50th Chief Justice of India.

Justice Chandrachud will represent Russia in an international arbitration tribunal hearing a dispute brought by Ukrainian state-owned bank Oschadbank.

The case pertains to the war between Russia and Ukraine and the claimed impact of military operations on the bank's operations.

The case stems from Oschadbank's claim over



assets and business operations in Ukraine's Donetsk, Luhansk, Kherson and Zaporizhzhia regions.

The bank says it lost these following Russia's military actions in Ukraine after 2022.

The dispute is being heard under the 1998 bilateral investment treaty between Russia and Ukraine, reported Bar and Bench. Oschadbank's claim is understood to be worth hun-

dreds of millions of dollars. The tribunal will have three members. Costa Rican arbitrator and former trade minister Dyalá Jimenez will serve as its president after being selected jointly by Russia and Oschadbank.

Greek arbitrator and National University of Singapore (NUS) professor Stavros Brekoulakis was chosen by Oschadbank as the third member.



Editor's
TAKE

What the Mecca defence pact really means

While the agreement offers no NATO-style collective defence, the military capabilities of its members – especially Turkey – warrant close attention

On August 7, Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan and Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif signed the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement, declaring that an attack on any one of the three would be treated as an attack on all. Coming after nearly a year of negotiation, and building on the bilateral Saudi-Pakistan defence pact signed in Riyadh last September, the accord instantly drew comparisons to NATO's Article 5. Predictable label – "Islamic NATO," – followed within hours.

The comparison is tempting but loose. Unlike NATO, the Mecca pact creates no integrated command, no standing joint forces, no automatic deployment mechanism. Riyadh itself has publicly denied this is a military alliance or a religious bloc. Pakistan has downplayed any suggestion of extending its nuclear umbrella to its new partners, and tellingly, Islamabad did not act militarily when Iran struck Saudi Arabia even after the bilateral pact was already in place.

What exists today is closer to a political signal of intent than a binding war-fighting compact. Yet the signal matters. The pact's timing – amid a widening US-Israel-Iran war, missile and drone strikes on Saudi oil infrastructure, and Gulf doubts about Washington's staying power – makes clear this is about hedging, not theology. Each partner brings something real: Saudi capital and geography astride two vital chokepoints, Turkey's NATO-standard military-industrial base, and Pakistan's battle-tested, nuclear-backed forces. Turkey has already said the door is open to more members; Egypt was courted but has stayed out, wary of binding commitments. The pact's chief strength, complementary capability, is also its weakness, since ambiguity over who must do what, and for whom, will only deepen as membership widens.

For India, the calculus is more complicated than the headlines suggest. The Ministry of External Affairs has responded with calibrated caution, saying only that it is "examining implications" for national security and regional stability. That restraint is sensible: no clause here extends Pakistan's nuclear deterrent, and Riyadh has too much invested in its India partnership, from energy to expatriate remittances, to want the pact read as anti-India. Still, two concerns are real. Turkey's role as a steady supplier of drones and defence hardware to Pakistan gives Islamabad a deeper-pocketed partner in modernising its arsenal. And a closer Ankara-Riyadh axis could complicate the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor, a project Turkey was pointedly excluded from and has actively worked to counter with a rival route. Both push New Delhi toward tightening its own hedges – with Israel, the UAE and Qatar, all now watching Riyadh's new company closely. The Mecca pact is not NATO, and treating it as an existential threat would be an overreaction. But it is a marker of a post-American security order taking shape on India's western flank, assembled by a nuclear-armed neighbour with newly diversified backers. That deserves sober, sustained attention – not alarm, but not complacency either.

A fitting response to Mecca pact

The Saudi Arabia-Pakistan-Türkiye defence pact may be premature to call an 'Islamic NATO', but it signals a changing security architecture in West Asia. For India, the challenge is not to counter the emerging grouping with another alliance, but to leverage its strategic autonomy, strengthen its maritime capabilities and deepen its partnerships across the region



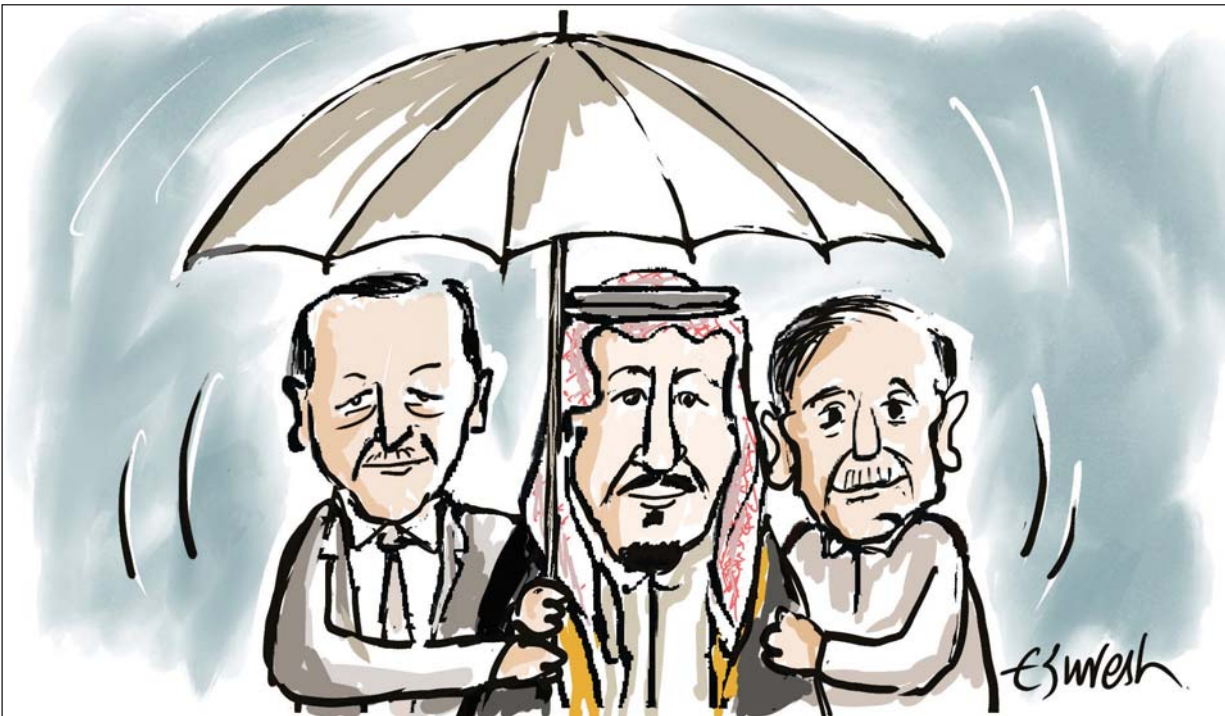
SATHOSH
MATHEW

The new defence pact between Saudi Arabia, Pakistan and Türkiye has opened a new chapter in West Asian geopolitics. It is already being called an "Islamic NATO", though that description may be premature. The three countries bring different strengths to the table. Pakistan is a nuclear-armed state with a large military, Türkiye is a NATO member with a growing defence industry, and Saudi Arabia is an oil-rich power with enormous financial resources and influence in the Muslim world. Their closer security cooperation is significant because it comes at a time when the old security architecture of the Gulf is changing rapidly. For India, Pakistan's role in this new arrangement makes the development particularly important.

For decades, the United States provided the main military shield for the Gulf. American bases, naval forces, aircraft and missile-defence systems offered protection to Saudi Arabia and other Gulf states. Recent conflicts involving Iran, Israel and the United States have exposed the limitations of depending entirely on an external power for regional security. Gulf countries are increasingly looking for their own partnerships and security arrangements. The Mecca pact reflects this wider search for strategic independence. It does not have NATO's permanent command structure or integrated military forces, but the direction is clear: West Asia is moving towards a more complicated system of regional security partnerships.

India cannot ignore this change. A stronger Pakistan-Saudi military relationship, combined with Türkiye's defence capabilities, could give Islamabad greater strategic and diplomatic space. At the same time, India has enormous interests in the Gulf. Millions of Indians live and work there, the region is crucial for India's energy security, and the Strait of Hormuz remains vital for global trade and oil supplies. Any major military confrontation in the Gulf can quickly affect India's economy, energy prices and maritime trade. India therefore needs to watch the new security equation carefully without treating it as an immediate military threat. The biggest danger would be a wider regional conflict in which Pakistan becomes directly involved.

India's answer should not be to create another military bloc. New Delhi's greatest advantage is its ability to maintain relation-



INDIA ALSO HAS
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NAVAL FLEETS

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ships with competing powers. India has strong partnerships with Saudi Arabia and the Gulf countries, strategic relations with the United States and Israel, and important ties with Iran and other West Asian states. This diplomatic flexibility should become a strategic asset.

The American experience also provides a lesson: decades of military protection did not eliminate instability in the Gulf. India should therefore strengthen its own capabilities rather than depend on another country's security umbrella. Dharma diplomacy, understood as responsible, balanced and dialogue-oriented statecraft, can complement India's traditional strategic autonomy.

The most natural arena for India's growing influence is the Indian Ocean. India's movement from SAGAR-Security and Growth for All in the Region to MAHASAGAR-Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions-should become the centre of its maritime strategy.

The Arabian Sea links India directly with the Gulf, while the wider Indian Ocean connects India with Africa, Southeast Asia and Europe. India can strengthen maritime surveillance, protect commercial shipping, expand naval cooperation, conduct humanitarian operations and help smaller countries build their maritime capabilities. Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam, the idea that the world is one family, can give this strategy a wider diplomatic purpose: India's secu-

PAKISTAN-SAUDI MILITARY
RELATIONSHIP, COMBINED WITH
TÜRKIYE'S DEFENCE
CAPABILITIES, COULD GIVE
ISLAMABAD GREATER STRATEGIC
AND DIPLOMATIC SPACE

urity need not depend on permanent confrontation with another country.

India also has another strategic opportunity-artificial intelligence. The future balance of power will not be decided only by nuclear weapons, fighter aircraft and naval fleets. AI, semiconductors, data, cyber technology and advanced computing will increasingly determine national power. India's MANAV approach, centred on moral and ethical systems, accountable governance, national sovereignty, accessibility, inclusion, validity and legitimacy, can provide a distinctly Indian voice in the global AI race.

Pakistan may have nuclear weapons, Türkiye may have advanced defence technology, and Saudi Arabia may possess immense financial power. India's answer can be a combination of technology, economic strength, maritime power and diplomacy. The message from Mecca should therefore push India towards MAHASAGAR-not towards another military alliance, but towards becoming a stronger maritime, technological and diplomatic power.

The quiet strength that builds civilisations



SIDDHARTH
ROY

2ND OPINION

Every civilisation leaves behind monuments that reflect its ambitions. Towers, temples, universities, bridges and highways become visible symbols of achievement, inspiring future generations to admire the societies that built them. Yet the true foundations of enduring nations are rarely made of concrete or stone. They are created through habits, values and attitudes that cannot be photographed, inaugurated or measured easily. Among these invisible assets, self-discipline remains the quiet strength that distinguishes temporary success from lasting national greatness.

Modern society has grown increasingly uneasy with the idea of discipline. It is often dismissed as restrictive, outdated or incompatible with individual freedom. We celebrate spontaneity, reward disruption and admire stories of overnight success. Social media reinforces the belief that

recognition should come instantly, while consumer culture encourages immediate gratification instead of patient effort. In such an environment, discipline appears unfashionable. Yet history repeatedly demonstrates that every nation which achieved sustained prosperity treated discipline not merely as a personal virtue but as a shared social value.

India's philosophical traditions recognised this truth centuries before economists began measuring productivity or competitiveness. The Bhagavad Gita teaches that mastering oneself is the highest victory. Swami Vivekananda argued that disciplined character forms the basis of national regeneration. Mahatma Gandhi transformed personal restraint into a powerful instrument of political and moral leadership. Though they lived in different eras, they shared one enduring conviction: societies become stronger only when individuals learn to govern themselves before attempting to influence others.

The experience of successful nations reinforces this lesson. Japan's remarkable recovery after the Second World War was sustained not only by financial assistance or industrial policy but also by a culture of punctuality, precision and continuous improvement. Germany's engineering excellence reflects generations of commitment to quality and accountability. Singapore's transformation into a global economic hub owes as much to civic responsibility as to visionary leadership. Infrastructure and institutions matter immensely, but they succeed only when citizens practise disciplined conduct in everyday life.

India today stands at a decisive moment. Massive investments are being made in infrastructure, manufacturing, technology and digital transformation. These initiatives are essential, but they cannot replace responsible behaviour. Roads become safer when traffic rules are respected. Public services improve when efficiency replaces delay. Businesses become globally competitive when employees pursue excellence instead of minimum compliance. Economic development depends as much on culture as it does on capital.

Self-discipline should therefore be regarded as national infrastructure. It requires little public expenditure, yet its returns are extraordinary. It strengthens institutions, discourages corruption, improves governance and builds workplaces where excellence becomes routine rather than exceptional.

Above all, it nurtures trust, the invisible currency upon which every successful economy and democracy ultimately depends. Civilisations seldom decline because they suddenly lose resources; they falter when responsibility yields to entitlement and discipline gives way to convenience. India's journey towards becoming a developed nation will ultimately be secured not only by visionary policies but by millions of ordinary citizens choosing disciplined action every single day.

The writer is a consultant to Rashtriya Raksha University under the Ministry of Home Affairs, a short story writer, columnist and contemporary affairs commentator

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Make or break situation of potholes

The number of potholes across Mumbai is growing day by day. Within a week of rains, 1,051 new potholes have cropped up, causing considerable inconvenience to road users. It is notable that the funds allocated for pothole repairs have been slashed to ₹14 crore this year, a reduction of Rs 11 crore compared with last year.

Mumbai appears to be fast acquiring the dubious distinction of having one of the highest numbers of potholes in the world. The BMC has to spend additional money every year during the monsoon to keep vehicles in good condition. Garages across the city remain busy as vehicles frequently break down on these damaged roads, while the condition of commuters worsens every time they venture out.

Potholes can damage tyres from the side and cause punctures. The effective way to address this problem is to identify badly affected roads and repair them using better, more durable technology. Roads deteriorate rapidly after even a few days of monsoon rain, making urgent repairs essential to prevent accidents.

It is high time Mumbai considered concrete roads for greater strength and durability, particularly as heavy traffic and monsoon conditions put additional pressure on the city's roads.

JAYANTHY S MANIAM | NAVI MUMBAI

Building the future for young India?

Apropos 'Today's youth: The torchbearers of tomorrow' (August 12, 2026) This International Youth Day reminds us that young people are not just passive recipients of our decisions. From Malala's fight for education to the recent student protests in India, they are actively shaping the national conversation with courage and clarity. Their actions show that age is no barrier to moral leadership, and we must listen carefully.

However, we must not romanticise their struggles. This generation faces rapid automation, climate change and an online world that often fuels anxiety. Their passion is inspiring, but they need strong institutional support to address systemic challenges

The response from governments and employers must go beyond symbolic acknowledgement. We need education systems that reward reasoning over rote memorisation and job markets that offer genuine opportunities, not just temporary fixes. Mental health support must also be treated as a serious public priority, not a private weakness. Ultimately, youth are indeed torchbearers, but we must provide the sturdy foundation they need to walk safely. If we match their idealism with concrete action, their path forward will be far less difficult. Only then can their potential truly transform our collective future.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

The politics of changing sides

Apropos 'Sparks fly in TN Assembly' (August 18). Neither Panneerselvam nor Sengottayan can claim the high moral ground on the issue of shifting alliances. While the former shifted to the DMK, the latter moved to the TVK from the AIADMK on the eve of the state elections. Evidently, both felt that their original party had become a sinking ship and it was time to move on to greener pastures. However, the actions of some other MLAs who switched over to the TVK after its electoral triumph are indefensible. None would object to a politician switching alliances or forming a new political party for ideological reasons or due to irreconcilable policy differences with the leadership. In 1950, Syama Prasad Mookerjee resigned from Nehru's Cabinet in protest over the Liaquat-Nehru Pact, alleging that it had failed to protect Hindu minorities in East Pakistan and compromised India's sovereignty. He went on to form a new party, the Jana Sangh.

In 1959, Rajaji resigned over the Congress government's socialist policies and nationalisation, calling it a 'Licence-permit-quota Raj'. He later founded the Swatantra Party, championing individual freedom. Despite their differences, neither he nor Nehru indulged in personal attacks or could be accused of selfishness or power-mongering.

V JAYARAMAN | CHENNAI

CHILDREN'S SAFETY: META FACES TOUGH QUESTIONS

At a time when the Indian government has recently issued a notice regarding advertisements containing child sexual content, Meta is also facing major legal trouble in the United States. Meta has been accused of adversely affecting the mental health of young people through Facebook and Instagram, and a New Mexico court has imposed a massive fine of approximately ₹5,400 crore on the company. Since March, the total amount of fines imposed on Meta has reportedly reached ₹9,030 crore. The court has ordered that the money be used for the mental health treatment of children.

The court compared Meta's operations to those of a factory causing toxic pollution. Just as a polluting factory poses a threat to public health, the court

observed that Meta's platforms similarly create risks to children's health. Meta will now develop a special AI-based age-verification system to identify unauthorised users under 13. Teachers and healthcare workers will also receive training to identify digital addiction.

A significant portion of the penalty will be spent on counselling and psychiatric treatment for children suffering from depression, anxiety and eating disorders. Following the court's action, Meta will also be required to disable push notifications at night for users under 18 and limit their monthly usage time. However, the real question is how effectively these restrictions will be implemented in practice.

ASHASWI BAIRAGI | UJJAIN

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PIC TALK



A woman offers prayers after tying thread to a tree on the 'Hariyali Amavasya' festival, in Ajmer. PHOTO: PTI

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Guarding against cognitive warfare and grey zone tactics

A positive outcome of the democratic contagion is the vindication that Parliament is the self-correcting and self-healing mechanism and is the barometer of people's hopes, aspirations, nay, frustrations. Indian Parliament is the unique institution to turn challenges into opportunities. Its resilience is its strength



RUP NARAYAN DAS

The protests against the paper leak last month, which snow-balled into a political agitation, can be seen through the prism of 'cognitive warfare' and grey-zone tactics. Cognitive warfare has gained traction in the age of new media. The agitation reached a crescendo on 20 July, when the Monsoon Session of Parliament started. The agitation was pre-planned and was not coincidental with the commencement of the Parliament session. In a democratic polity of a 'soft state' like India, protests and agitation within and outside Parliament are aspects of democratic discourse. What is bemoaned is the organised effort to ask for regime change of an elected government. Its execution was meticulously orchestrated with moral and material support from within and outside, including inimical forces in India's neighbourhood and beyond. The simultaneous demonstrations abroad in support of the agitation are intriguing, suggesting a wider network in connivance with domestic political forces to destabilise India and stymie India's growth and development. The biased news reports and write-ups in foreign media outlets were suggestive of the jaundiced outlook of the Western media. While the paper leak issue is a serious issue and the bona fide students' angst warranted urgent remedial action, the anger and anguish of students were very adroitly calibrated and reinforced in the political space, when Parliament was in session, to create an optic of mayhem.

IF THE RECENT PROTESTS WERE MOTIVATED TO FIX SYSTEMIC LACUNAE, ONE CAN EMPATHISE WITH THE STUDENTS; BUT THE FACT IS THAT THE AGITATION AIMED AT DESTABILISING AN ELECTED GOVERNMENT

When an agitation of such magnitude occurs, some law-and-order issues are bound to crop up. Although there have been some cases of injuries sustained by both the students and the police, the agitation was deftly handled by both the government and the police without serious casualties. The revelation by the police that there was a sizeable chunk of hardcore criminal elements, as identified by a facial recognition system, is intriguing.

Political protests and agitation are part and parcel of India's adversarial and contested politics, which has been in existence since the country's protracted freedom struggle. Post-independent India has also witnessed such protests and movements, the most important in our recent memory being the 'Total Revolution' in Bihar and the Navnirman Movement in Gujarat, spearheaded by Jayaprakash Narayan in 1974, which eventually brought the first non-Congress government in the country in 1977 after the National Emergency. The Mandal agitation of 1990 is also in our minds. All these agitations had the strong support of the student community. But none of these movements ever had any overt or covert support from abroad, as is alleged in the recent protest against the paper leak. All the previous movements, except the farmers' agitation of 2020, were home-grown and were led by towering leaders of impeccable credentials.

While wars have been transformed from conventional warfare to nuclear warfare to drones, the battlefields themselves have been expanded to trade war, cyberwar and cognitive warfare, and what the Chinese often resort to as 'united front' tactics. Strategists of cognitive warfare aim to exploit people's resentment, frustrations and cynicism to unseat a ruling regime. They attempt to paint a narrative of defeatism, taking advantage of the vulnerability of a soft state, democracy and constitutional guarantees of freedom of expression, including freedom of protest, and the existence of an independent and zealous judiciary and civil society. Though the paper leak was a serious issue and students had genuine grievances, the issue was effectively chore-



ographed through a ragtag coalition of forces and endorsement by celebrities.

It is no exaggeration to say that while gullible students were hypnotised, lumpen elements were hired to indulge in arson and vandalism. The masterminds of the protest and agitation have done a great disservice to Gen Z, who are in adolescence and at an impressionable age. There is a need to understand their socio-psychological state of mind and engage them creatively in their career-building, in alignment with nation-building. Unlike their previous generations, Gen Z have grown up in relatively better economic security, some even in affluence. Consumerism under the impact of globalisation has induced their material aspirations, added to and abetted by demonstrative effects. Their desires have become demands. This 'wired generation' has not seen the hard way their parents brought them up and their tenacity to fight against adversities, including hunger and poverty. They almost got things on a platter. Growing up in a protective environment, they lack the killer instinct or fire in the belly.

If the recent protests were purely motivated to fix systemic lacunae, one can empathise with the students; but the fact is that the agitation aimed at destabilising and changing an elected government. Taking the fight to the streets may be a democratic way of protest, but taking the law into one's hands and vandalising public property is not acceptable. Constitutional rights are not a licence to take the law into one's hands and indulge in filthy and abusive verbiage. No wonder, therefore, that the builder of modern Singapore, Lee Kuan Yew, lamented the 'exuberance' of democracy as detrimental to development. It is ironical that while the West criticises India's 'messy democracy', it has no qualms about instigating instability in the country. The hidden agenda of the West behind awarding leaders of civil society and litterateurs with coveted honours such as the Magsaysay Awards, Fulbright Scholarships, Ford Foundation awards or Booker Prizes are concealed, and these are long-term investments in individuals to incubate narratives to destabilise the country. This, however, does not reflect on the merits of the awards.

One need not be a rocket scientist to identify such Trojan horses.

A positive outcome of the democratic contagion is the vindication that Parliament is the self-correcting and self-healing mechanism and is the barometer of people's hopes, aspirations, nay, frustrations. Indian Parliament is the unique institution to turn challenges into opportunities. Its resilience is its strength.

The writer is a former Senior Fellow of the Indian Council of Social Science Research and currently a Consulting Editor of the Journal of Parliamentary Information

The stairs to the podium



VIRENDRA SACHDEVA

In the summer of 1934, six Indians boarded a ship for London. They were headed to the second edition of what was then called the British Empire Games, the tournament the world now knows as the Commonwealth Games. When the Games ended, India had exactly one medal to show for the journey: a bronze, won by wrestler Rashid Anwar. Ninety-two years later, Commonwealth Games, Glasgow, 2026, a very different India walked out. A contingent of 122 athletes competed across ten sports and came home with 39 medals: 13 gold, 17 silver and nine bronze! And eight of those thirteen golds were won by women. The distance between those two contingents, six athletes and one bronze, versus a nation now expecting to place among the top handful of Commonwealth countries, is the real story of Indian sport.

It is not a story written slowly, by athletes who trained day and night, by coaches who worked relentlessly, by parents who gave their everything. But it is impossible to tell the new India's story without placing Prime Minister Narendra Modi close to its centre. Who, more than any leader before him, chose to treat sport as a national priority rather than an afterthought. By providing support to athletes who had never been funded, building the schemes that changed their odds, and lending the prestige of his office to a boxer or a javelin thrower the way earlier prime ministers reserved for statesmen.

After the lone 1934 bronze, the medals came slowly. It took until 1958, in Cardiff, for India to win its first Commonwealth gold, and it was won by a man whose life had begun in tragedy. Milkha Singh, the 'Flying Sikh,' had survived the horrors of Partition as an orphaned teenager before he ever set foot on a track. When he stormed to victory in the 440 yards, he became the first Indian to top a Commonwealth podium. The same Games saw Stephanie D'Souza and Elizabeth Davenport become the first Indian women ever to compete at the event, a quiet milestone that took a full generation to fully bloom.

Through the 1960s, '70s and '80s, India's fortunes rose in fits and starts, carried mostly on the backs of wrestlers and, later, weightlifters and shooters. Jaspal Rana's shooting brilliance and Raghavan Chandrasekaran's weightlifting hauls kept the tricolour flying. But for most of these decades, the story of the Indian athlete was a story of scarcity: sport was something you pursued despite the system, not because of it. Lack of facilities, foreign exposure was rare, and funding was an afterthought. To understand how much has changed, it helps to sit with one story. Saikhom Mirabai Chanu grew up in a village in Manipur, the kind of place where a child's first "weight training" is carrying firewood up a hill. As a teenager training in Imphal, her childhood coach has recalled, there were days Mirabai did not have even ₹10 for the bus fare home. She would say she had gone home for just five days in five years, so complete was her devotion to the sport. But the new India tells another story.

In April 2021, three months before the Tokyo Olympics, Mirabai needed to reach a specialist strength-and-conditioning coach in the United States. The Delta wave was raging; countries were shutting their doors to Indian travellers. The entire trip, from treatment to a sparring partner, boarding, lodging and travel, was budgeted at around ₹70 lakh. According to her coach, the sanction came through in a single day. "I never thought a day like this would come," he said, "when you could even ask for an amount like this." She flew out just before the travel ban slammed shut, trained, and returned to win an Olympic silver medal, India's first medal of those Games!

The girl who once lacked bus fare had her elite overseas training approved in twenty-four hours. The funding that reached Mirabai was not luck. It flowed through a set of programmes built up over the last decade, and Mirabai is not the only one. In 2014, Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi launched TOPS (The Target Olympic Podium Scheme). The scheme was designed to do one focused thing: identify India's top sports talent and remove money as an obstacle. Under TOPS, the government funds not just the athlete but the entire support structure: foreign coaches, physiotherapists, sparring partners, video analysts, airfare and medical insurance. TOPS helped javelin thrower Kishore Jena when he needed 78 days of training in Australia before Paris 2024. When PV Sindhu trained in Germany and Neeraj Chopra's whole athletics setup was backed to the hilt, TOPS was the reason. Khelo India, launched in 2018, works at the other end of the pipeline.

Through the Khelo India Youth Games and University Games, held annually, the system scouts for talent at the school and college level and channels promising athletes into structured support long before they are famous. In early 2025, after the National Games in Uttarakhand, the Prime Minister singled out a clutch of young Khelo India products by name, sprinters, jumpers, a teenage swimmer, as evidence that the pipeline was working. Prime Minister understands the emotional register of sport. Congratulating national award winners the other day, he said: "There is no elevator to success - you have to take the stairs." In later years, initiatives like Fit India and his repeated emphasis on fitness in Mann Ki Baat have made such a deep impact because they change what an ambitious young person from a small town believes is possible for them. India has now openly declared its intent to bid for the 2036 Olympic Games and is set to host the Commonwealth Games again in 2030. Ask any Indian medalist who made them, and the first names are always the same: a coach who refused to give up on them, their parents who sold or mortgaged what little the family had. That will never change, and it shouldn't. But something new has entered that circle of gratitude over the last decade, and the athletes themselves have been the ones to put it there.

When the Tokyo Olympics contingent, India's best-ever haul of seven medals, gathered at the Prime Minister's residence in August 2021, they did not arrive empty-handed. Neeraj Chopra handed the PM the very javelin he had thrown to India's historic gold. PV Sindhu gave her badminton racquet, Lovlina Borgohain her boxing gloves, Bhavani Devi her fencing sword, the hockey teams their autographed sticks. When young javelin thrower Navdeep Singh wanted to place a cap on Modi's head, the Prime Minister sat down on the floor so the athlete could reach him. This is the humility and respect the Prime Minister has always given to the athletes, and these are the gestures of people who feel genuinely seen. In fact, that feeling of being seen is, in a way, the whole point, and it began before the medals. Back in 2016, when Modi personally hosted a send-off for the Rio-bound contingent, Abhinav Bindra, India's only individual Olympic gold medalist, tweeted his astonishment: it was the first time a Prime Minister had ever sent the Olympic team off in person. When a nation's leader treats its athletes not as an afterthought but as the face of what the country can become, something shifts in every small-town child who dreams of the podium. That is the quiet inheritance Narendra Modi leaves Indian sport.



The writer is the Secretary General, Archery Association of India and the Executive Board Member, World Archery Asia

India's edible oil mission: Opportunities, challenges and the road ahead



ASHISH KHANDELWAL

India is one of the largest producers of oilseeds but still imports 55 per cent-60 per cent of its edible oil requirements. Annually, more than \$20 billion is spent on the import of palm, soybean and sunflower oil from Indonesia, Malaysia, Argentina, Ukraine and Russia. This was exposed sharply during the post-COVID commodity price surge of 2021-22, which saw the prices of edible oil double overnight. This led to the government introducing a much-needed policy directive, the National Mission on Edible Oils — Oil Palm (NMEO-OP), which is aimed at strengthening the ecosystem of India's edible oils.

The National Mission on Edible Oils was the need of the hour because the import bill on edible oil was rising and became the third-highest import bill after crude petroleum and gold. This mission is not just ensuring food security for a population exceeding 1.4 billion but economic security for the country as well. We can achieve this in three ways:

The Palm Oil Pivot: India's edible oil ecosystem is heavily reliant on palm oil. However, things are now changing for good. Almost ₹11,040 crore over five years was allocated in

2021 for expanding palm oil cultivation to 10 lakh hectares by 2025-26 and 16.7 lakh hectares by 2029-30. This primarily targets the North-East and Andaman & Nicobar Islands. These areas have suitable agro-climatic conditions. Through this mission, farmers have been guaranteed prices through a viability price mechanism, ensured buyback commitments and provided substantial planting subsidies.

Palm oil is a great solution for farmers since it yields far more oil per hectare than any other oilseed crop. In comparative terms, the yield of palm oil is five times the yield of edible oil obtainable from traditional oilseeds. As per estimates, a hectare of palm oil cultivation can produce 3-4 tonnes of crude palm oil annually, compared to 0.3-0.4 tonnes from groundnut or mustard. Even a modest scaling of palm oil cultivation will make a meaningful reduction in our dependence on imports. The Mustard and Soybean Story: The government has also leaned heavily on mustard and soybean as the more immediate levers of domestic production. Mustard's acreage has been growing on the back of minimum support price (MSP) hikes and improved seed availability. In 2022-23, India's mustard output reached a record 12.4 million



tonnes. This was a massive improvement, and it provided some domestic buffer against import price spikes.

However, the biggest challenge for India is yield stagnation. India's productivity lags far behind global benchmarks. India's average mustard yield is 1,200-1,400 kg per hectare vis-à-vis 1,800-2,000 kg in leading producing nations. For soyabean, the gap is even starker. We need to bridge this yield gap. This can be achieved through sustained investment in certified seed

distribution, micro-irrigation, soil health and agri-extension services - areas where implementation has historically been uneven. Reducing gaps in processing and value chain: Growing more oilseeds is only half the job done. There is a huge gap when it comes to crushing and refining infrastructure. This gap is substantial and has been characterised by fragmentation, geographic concentration and underutilisation in key production regions. We need a seamless integration of the farm-to-refinery value chain. This must be

supported by adequate storage, cold-chain support for perishable produce and quality-testing infrastructure. This is a must if we want to translate higher crop output into lower consumer prices.

The edible oil mission opened up several opportunity windows for the industry. Firstly, it has put the North-East in the focal point as it is an under-explored agricultural frontier with rainfall, humidity and land availability well-suited to oil palm. Integrated development by combining plantation, processing and rural livelihoods will immensely transform the region's agricultural economy while contributing meaningfully to national supply.

Secondly, nascent segments like rice bran oil, groundnut oil and cold-pressed varieties have emerged as high-value, high-margin opportunities for domestic producers. This has been augmented by rising urban consumer health consciousness. Lastly, the oilseed-to-biofuel roadmap offers a strategic advantage. Demand for biofuel, thanks to the government's blending policy, has created a secondary demand channel.

There is no doubt that India's edible oil self-sufficiency is achievable, but it will require patience, policy consistency and coordinated action across agriculture, trade, infrastructure and R&D. The Edible Oil Mission is a long game, and we need to play it well.

The writer is an agro-economy policy analyst and writes on agriculture, economy and rural India



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Order Order

SC to hear plea on disruption of essential services during protest



The Supreme Court on Wednesday agreed to hear a plea which raised the issue of disruption of essential services during protests.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was told by the counsel appearing for the petitioner that essential services were disrupted when protests were underway and ingress and egress was disturbed. The counsel said there is no way of knowing who is a protestor and who is not and the issue of disruption of essential services during protests is arising across the country.

"We appreciate your concerns but how to issue a direction for that," the bench told the counsel. The apex court tagged the petition with a separate pending plea which has contended that the Jantar Mantar in Delhi was no longer a suitable venue for protests as they cause inconvenience to local residents and disrupt essential services.

The top court on August 3 agreed to examine the separate PIL which seeks an alternative arrangement for holding demonstrations, saying protests at Jantar Mantar create difficulties for local residents and disrupts the supply of essential goods and medical services. (PTI)

Cauvery plea to be taken up on August 17: Supreme Court



The Supreme Court on Wednesday said pleas of the Tamil Nadu Government and others, including the DMK, seeking directions to the Karnataka Government to immediate release Cauvery waters to it will be taken up for hearing on August 17.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana had earlier said the Tamil Nadu government's plea will be taken up for hearing on Thursday, August 13.

On Wednesday, senior advocate P Wilson, appearing for some farmers, mentioned a separate plea for urgent listing. "This was to come up tomorrow before Justice Vikram Nath (led bench). But he is not well," the CJI said.

Earlier, the Tamil Nadu Government had said the state was not getting its due share of Cauvery water in a rain deficient year. The Joseph Vijay led-state Government on August 3 approached the Supreme Court seeking directions to the Karnataka Government for immediate release of the water. The state government, in its plea, claimed that the quantum allocated to it by the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee (CWRC) as well as that released by its neighbour Karnataka was far less.

A CWRC meeting held on July 28 directed Karnataka to release 3,500 cusecs for 15 days starting July 29. However, the quantum of water released at Biligundlu ranged between 158 and 550 cusecs from July 29 to August 2, the State Government said. (PTI)

Mathura: SC mulls remanding to HC plea over who represents all Krishna devotees

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday indicated that it may send the plea related to a dispute over whose lawsuit will be the lead case in the Krishna Janmabhoomi-Shahi Idgah mosque dispute back to the Allahabad High Court.

A bench of Justices Sanjay Kumar and Sanjeev Sachdeva said notices were not issued to other plaintiffs by the high court, which treated another Hindu party, in another suit, as a representative of all devotees of Lord Krishna. "The application was for something else and notices were not issued to all the plaintiffs. We in any case are inclined to remand the matter back to the high court," it observed.

The apex court posted the matter for further hearing on September 2.

During the last hearing of the matter, the bench said, a



statement was made across the bar by some counsels that off-the-record talks were going on between plaintiffs (Hindu parties) on whose lawsuit will be the lead case in the matter.

Senior advocate Shyam Divan, appearing for some Hindu parties, urged the court to remand the matter back to the high court for deciding the issue afresh.

The top court was hearing a plea of a Hindu party in the matter challenging a 2025 Allahabad High Court order, which treated another Hindu

Frame policy on regularisation of illegal constructions, SC to States

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday asked all states and Union territories to consider a representation seeking framing of uniform policy for regularisation and demolition of long-standing unauthorised constructions across the country.

The order was passed by the top court while declining to entertain a PIL filed by Centre for Law and Good Governance seeking directions to the Centre and all the states for framing such a policy to save unauthorised dwelling units of poor persons, saying that this issue largely falls within the policy domain of state governments and local authorities.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana said that circumstances and ground realities vary from state to state, making it neither feasible nor prudent for the court to prescribe a single policy frame-



work for the entire country.

"It would be difficult and may not be prudent for this court to lay down a uniform policy framework to be applied across various states," the bench said. The court, however, said states and Union territories could consider the issues raised in the petition while formulating new policies or revisiting their existing frameworks.

"We are hopeful that due consideration shall be given to all such issues by the competent authorities," the bench said in its order.

The petition pointed out that settlement and regular-

isation schemes have been introduced in states such as Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, as well as in Delhi.

It, however, alleged that in several instances, unauthorised colonies and structures were demolished suddenly, sometimes without adequate notice and without any rehabilitation or welfare mechanism for affected families.

The PIL said that demolition is an extreme and irreversible measure and therefore cannot be undertaken without a policy that balances enforcement of planning and land-use laws with the constitutional rights to

shelter, livelihood and dignity under Article 21.

The counsel for the petitioner said that state governments follow inconsistent approaches towards unauthorised constructions.

According to the plea, demolitions are at times carried out in a hurried, erratic and unsystematic manner.

The counsel said that authorities sometimes assure residents that unauthorised structures would be regularised, while simultaneously collecting municipal and property taxes and permitting access to civic amenities such as electricity.

After 40-50 years, residents may be told that their structures are illegal and face demolition without any assessment of whether alternative accommodation is available.

The plea urged the bench to examine the issue from a human-rights perspective, particularly in cases involving families who have remained in possession of properties or colonies for decades.

BBMB dispute: Punjab close to settlement, Government to SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre on Wednesday told the Supreme Court that the Punjab Government is very close to agreeing to its proposal on the issue of payment of dues to Himachal Pradesh arising out of the Bhakra Beas Management Board (BBMB) projects since 1966.

On July 30, the Centre had told the apex court that an amicable settlement can be reached on a new cashless formula between the partner states for payment of arrears.

The top court had then recorded that the governments of Himachal and Haryana have in principle agreed to the Centre's proposal but the Punjab Government has objected.

The apex court had pulled up the Punjab Government for not agreeing to the proposal, observing that it has the habit



of not following the decree of the court. On Wednesday, senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for the Himachal Pradesh government, told a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana that the apex court has listed the matter for finding out whether the Punjab Government is agreeable to the Centre's proposal or not.

"I must say now today we speak in a joint voice.

Punjab is coming very closer," Attorney General R Venkataramani, appearing for

the Centre, told the bench.

"I think we are going to iron out the creases," Venkataramani said and requested the bench to list the matter for hearing next week. The bench posted the matter for hearing on August 20. According to sources, BBMB is paying 7.19 per cent share of Himachal Pradesh's electricity from Bhakra Beas projects after November 1, 2011, while Punjab and Haryana have not paid the outstanding dues of BBMB projects for the previous period, which is 13,066 million units.

7-judge SC bench to hear issue concerning legislative privileges on October 6

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A seven-judge Constitution bench would commence hearing on October 6 on the interpretation of provisions related to the scope of legislative privileges of MLAs and its effect on the freedom of speech and expression, the Supreme Court said on Wednesday.

A separate issue concerning the power of the state legislature to impose additional levy on sales tax will be heard by a seven-judge bench from September 22, it said.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V

Mohana said the matter slated for September 22 would be heard from 2 pm to 4 pm in the post-lunch session so that hearing in other matters could go on in the pre-lunch session.

"One way is to list the matter for hearing from 2 pm to 4 pm. That will allow us to hear fresh and other miscellaneous matters also," the CJI observed.

He said another way was to hear the arguments for the whole day on three days a week — Tuesday, Wednesday and Thursday.

The bench said hearing in the matter listed on October 6 would commence preferably at 11 am.

The issue concerning the



interpretation of provisions related to the scope of legislative privileges of MLAs and its interplay with the fundamental right to freedom of speech and expression was referred

Kerala HC sets aside denial of FCRA renewal of two NGOs for funding Vizhinjam protests

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kochi

The Kerala High Court has set aside the Centre's decision not to renew the FCRA certificate of two NGOs, accused by central agencies of funding agitations against the Vizhinjam sea port, saying that financial support to a protest cannot be seen as diversion of foreign funds.

The High Court said that the right to protest is guaranteed under the Constitution and therefore, financial support to protestors cannot be seen as a diversion of foreign funds for an undesirable purpose or against public interest, tantamounting to violation of any provision in the Foreign Contribution Regulation Act (FCRA).

"When the right to protest is constitutionally guaranteed, exercise of such rights cannot be labelled as an undesirable purpose or



against public interest.

The term undesirable purpose in section 12(4)(a)(ii) of the FCRA cannot be interpreted to mean undesirable to the Government or undesirable to the political will.

"A peaceful protest against a project by persons who have a grievance or who apprehend injury to them, cannot be viewed as an undesirable purpose due to a political disapproval," it said in order dated August 11.

The court also said that "executive or administrative

distaste" for protests or dis-sents, cannot convert the exercise of a constitutionally protected right into an undesirable purpose or as against public interest.

"Thus, even if it is assumed that some financial support was provided to the protestors, it cannot be treated as diversion of foreign contribution for an undesirable purpose or against public interest, tantamounting to violation of any provision in the FCRA," it said.

Allahabad HC directs UP police body to produce results of promotion exams

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

The Allahabad High Court has directed the Uttar Pradesh Police Recruitment and Promotion Board to produce the complete results of all 176 candidates who appeared in a departmental examination for promotion to head constable (motor transport) amid allegations of large-scale cheating and malpractice using electronic devices.

The Lucknow bench of the high court, presided over by Justice Rajeev Singh, also directed the Board to place before it the sitting plan of the selected candidates. The matter has been listed for further hearing on August 13.

The directions came on a petition filed by constable-drivers, including SB Mishra, challenging the departmental examination held on October 5, 2025, for



promotion from constable driver to head constable (motor transport).

The petitioners have alleged widespread use of electronic devices for cheating and sought cancellation of the examination and a fresh test under strict surveillance.

They have also challenged the subsequent results and shortlisting for

view their own results, she said. Initially, the authorities had informed the court that only two candidates were found using mobile phones and no unauthorised devices had been detected among other candidates.

However, following the court's directions, an inquiry was conducted. On July 22, Pathak informed the court that 115 candidates had been found involved in malpractice and they were debarred.

The court directed the Board to preserve CCTV footage from all eight examination blocks. Relevant digital records were produced before the court on August 10 and taken into custody.

The court directed that the examination recordings, including video footage and photographs, be examined to assist in adjudicating the dispute.

HC refuses urgent hearing of plea for interim protection by Abhishek Banerjee's personal assistant

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Calcutta High Court on Wednesday refused an urgent hearing of TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee's personal assistant Sumit Roy, who sought protection from coercive action in connection with some cases registered against him.

The Supreme Court and the high court had earlier granted relief to Roy in alleged land-grabbing and cash-for-jobs scam cases, respectively.

Refusing an urgent listing of the matter for hearing, Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya said that upgrading Roy's petition was not possible as numerous similar pleas were pending before the court, and his petition will appear according to the listing serial.

Roy's lawyer stated that the Supreme Court had granted him anticipatory bail and he was meeting the investigating officer as per summons.

He had appeared before the state CID at its Kolkata headquarters. His counsel said



that Roy is, however, vulnerable to police action in other cases registered against him, and sought an urgent hearing for grant of interim protection from coercive action by the police authorities.

The apex court had stayed Roy's arrest last week in connection with an alleged land-grabbing case in West Bengal's Salboni, while directing him to fully cooperate with the ongoing investigation.

Roy had been granted anticipatory bail by the high court in another case related to an alleged cash-for-jobs scam.



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Tata Motors Q1 net profit jumps 83% to ₹2,556 crore



Commercial vehicle maker Tata Motors Ltd on Wednesday reported an 83 per cent jump in consolidated net profit at ₹2,556 crore in the first quarter ended June 30, led by a mark to market gain on investments in Tata Capital Ltd. The company had posted a consolidated net profit of ₹1,397 crore in the corresponding quarter previous fiscal, Tata Motors Ltd said in a regulatory filing.

Consolidated total revenue from operations in the first quarter stood at ₹20,667 crore as against ₹17,324 crore in the year-ago period, it added. Vehicle wholesales in the quarter stood at 1,08,700 units, a growth of 26 per cent over the year-ago period, it said.

Total expenses in the quarter under review were higher at ₹18,038 crore as compared to ₹15,982 crore in the same period a year ago, the company said.

Commenting on the performance, Tata Motors Ltd MD & CEO Girish Wagh said, "Tata Motors delivered a strong quarter, with volumes growing 26 per cent year-on-year, driven by a winning portfolio, focused market interventions, and disciplined execution. These efforts helped us strengthen customer preference and further consolidate our market position." He said the commercial vehicle industry remained resilient in Q1 FY27, supported by India's strong economic fundamentals, healthy fleet utilisation, and sustained demand across key sectors. On the company's acquisition of Iveco update, Tata Motors said the regulatory approvals are in the final stage, with only one approval pending, the company said.

Axis Bank raises \$300 million via bonds



Axis Bank on Wednesday said it has raised \$300 million (about ₹2,850 crore) by selling bonds to overseas investors to fund business growth.

The bank has successfully allotted \$300 million in senior notes at a coupon of 5.348 per cent, the bank said in a regulatory filing.

The said notes will be consolidated and form a single series with the \$300,000,000 5.348 per cent, it said.

The issuance and allotment of the notes have been completed in accordance with the applicable laws and regulatory requirements, the bank said.

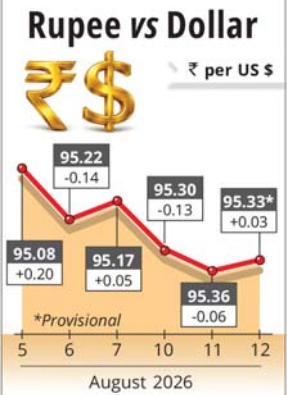
The notes will be listed on Global Securities Market of the India International Exchange (IFSC) Ltd and Debt Securities Market of the NSE IFSC Ltd, it added.

Rupee rises 3 paise to close at 95.33 against US dollar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The rupee settled just 3 paise higher at 95.33 (provisional) against the US dollar on Wednesday, as hopes of a quick US-Iran agreement and reopening of the Strait of Hormuz faded.

Forex traders said Brent crude is moving towards \$90 per barrel amid risk aversion in global markets.



At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 95.40 against the greenback and traded in a range of 95.24-95.43 during the session. It eventually settled at 95.33 (provisional), higher by 3 paise from its previous close.



Coal India, AMNS sign pact for synthesis gas utilisation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned Coal India Ltd on Wednesday said it has entered into a pact with ArcelorMittal Nippon Steel India Pvt Ltd (AMNS) to explore the utilisation of synthesis gas produced from a proposed coal gasification plant near the steelmaker's Paradip pellet plant in Odisha.

The memorandum of understanding (MoU), executed on Wednesday, envisages a coal gasification facility to be established by CIL adjacent to or at the AMNS Paradip Pellet Plant, coupled with carbon capture, utilisation and storage (CCUS) technology, according to a regulatory filing by Coal India Ltd (CIL).



Under the initial framework, both the companies will assess the technical and commercial feasibility of the

proposed project, examine implementation modalities and facilitate the preparation of a Preliminary Feasibility

Report (PFR) to evaluate its viability.

Coal gasification converts coal into synthesis gas (syn-

gas), and steelmakers use this as a cleaner fuel and chemical reducing agent.

It replaces imported natural gas and is injected into blast furnaces to reduce reliance on expensive, imported coking coal.

Coal India accounts for over 80 per cent of domestic coal output.

The Union Cabinet had earlier approved a ₹37,500-crore incentive scheme to promote coal gasification projects, aimed at boosting clean energy production and reducing dependence on forex-guzzling imports of LNG, urea and methanol, while insulating the country from global price volatility and supply chain disruptions.

The Union Cabinet under the chairmanship of Prime

Minister Narendra Modi approved the scheme for promotion of surface coal/lignite gasification projects with a financial outlay of ₹37,500 crore.

The scheme marks a major step towards accelerating the country's coal gasification programme, advancing the national target of gasifying 100 million tonnes (MT) of coal by 2030, strengthening energy security, and reducing dependence on imports of key products such as LNG, urea, ammonia and methanol.

India holds one of the world's largest coal reserves of 401 billion tonnes and lignite reserves of 47 billion tonnes.

Coal accounts for over 55 per cent of the country's energy mix.

NTPC concludes national finale of Medha Pratiyogita 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

NTPC Ltd successfully concluded the national finale of Medha Pratiyogita 2026 at its Power Management Institute (PMI), Noida, with 24 teams competing across four categories-Junior, Middle, Senior and Employee.

The annual flagship event witnessed participation from 1,863 teams from across NTPC projects and regions, providing a platform for employees and their families to compete in a spirit of healthy competition.

The competition commenced with the Unit/Project-level Written Round on July 12, 2026, followed by regional rounds held at Korba, Ramagundam, Talcher Kaniha, Nabinagar, Dadri and PMI, Noida. The



event culminated in the National Finale on Tuesday.

The National Finale was contested by six teams in each of the four categories, taking the total number of participating finalist teams to 24.

The winners in the four categories were:

● Junior: Ahaan and

Devayansh Singh — Western Region

● Middle: Utkarsh Parikh and Darsh Jain — Northern Region

● Senior: Tanmay Verma and Harshit Sharma — Northern Region

● Employee: Anshuman Shrivastav and Shubham Mishra — Western Region

Each winning team was

awarded ₹30,000 in prize money, along with a Certificate of Excellence. The awards were presented by Shri Anil Kumar Jadli, Director (HR), NTPC Ltd.

Medha Pratiyogita is one of NTPC's annual flagship initiatives that promotes a culture of learning among its employees and their families.

About NTPC Ltd

NTPC Limited, a Maharatna company of the Government of India, is India's largest integrated energy company, with an installed capacity of over 90 GW. The company is leading the charge toward a sustainable future, targeting 60 GW of renewable energy capacity by 2032 and investing in emerging technologies such as nuclear power, battery energy storage, carbon capture and green chemicals.

No manipulation observed in closing auction sessions: SEBI Chairman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

SEBI chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey on Wednesday said that the capital markets regulator has not observed any manipulations in the newly introduced closing auction sessions system.

Speaking on the sidelines of an event here, Pandey urged the broader ecosystem to understand the new system and adopt it. He said a lot of markets, including those in Australia, Europe, the US and Japan, have adopted a similar system for over two years and India is behind its counterparts.

He said such a system, which was started on August 3, is useful for passive investors, generation of the correct net asset values for mutual funds and index investors. The earlier system had the risk of manipulation with late trades, he added. When asked if the regulator has seen any manipulation in the new system, he said no manipulation has been observed.

"Basically, the CAS is a transparent



market, the pricing there is always visible and participation should grow in it," Pandey said, adding that SEBI is engaged with all the stakeholders to understand their feedback.

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) is willing to tweak the system if need be, he said, adding that at present, our problem is with understanding the system.

Meanwhile, SEBI is mulling to come out with a new paper on its findings on the losses suffered by retail investors in the derivatives market in the next 8-10 days, according to Pandey.

He said some of the results will surprise the ecosystem and stressed that such strategies of executing trades on expiry days are not as simple as they are made out to be by some retail investors.

Earlier, speaking at the Global Commodity Conclave, Pandey said the growth in the market is encouraging, but the scale alone is not enough as India is a major producer and consumer of several commodities.

"Can that economic weight translate into greater influence over price discovery? Can we move from being price takers to becoming price makers?" the SEBI chairman asked.

The capital markets watchdog is examining wider foreign portfolio investor access to commodity indices and physically settled non-agri contracts through a calibrated framework, he said.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai



0.24 per cent, to settle at 77,966.35. During the day, it tumbled 656.32 points, or 0.83 per cent, to 77,497.93.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dipped 35.75 points, or 0.15 per cent, to end at 24,435.95.

From the Sensex pack, TCS dropped the most by 3.71 per cent.

Mahindra & Mahindra, Tata Steel, Larsen & Toubro, Eternal and Infosys were also among the laggards.

State Bank of India, Bharti Airtel, UltraTech Cement and Power Grid were among the winners.

TPCI sets up national committee to promote pet food industry growth

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Industry body Trade Promotion Council of India (TPCI) on Wednesday said it has set up a national committee to promote growth and innovation for the fast pet food industry.

Pet food refers to prepared food, treats and nutrition products intended for companion animals and generally meant for dogs or cats, put up for retail sale.



The Indian pet food market is expanding rapidly as urban consumers shift from home-cooked feeding to packaged nutrition, it said.

As per market estimates, the global pet food market size is \$226.31 billion in 2026

and is expected to reach \$324.17 billion by 2031.

India's market is estimated at \$0.98 billion in 2026 and \$1.68 billion by 2031, it added.

North America is the largest region with a 44.1 per cent share in 2025 and Africa is the fastest-growing region for 2026-2031.

It added that India remains a net importer of pet food, which indicates dependence on premium, therapeutic, wet, specialised and imported-brand products.

projects have not witnessed material rating pressure from transmission delays so far, supported by repayment moratoriums, liquidity buffers, and sponsor support mechanisms.

However, prolonged transmission bottlenecks could weaken capital structure and lead to sustained reliance on sponsors.

Utility-backed projects benefit from partial protection, as the scheduled commercial operation date (SCOD) under power purchase agreements (PPA) is allowed till 30-60 days post-receipt of the final GNA.

Growing gap between renewable energy, transmission capacity key credit risk: Ind-Ra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India Ratings and Research (Ind-Ra) on Wednesday said the growing gap between renewable energy (RE) commissioning and transmission readiness is emerging as a key credit risk for the sector.

Around 112 GW of the planned 196 GW RE pipeline till FY32 remains aligned with transmission schedules, about 84 GW of capacity faces delays in general network access (GNA) operationalisation, highlighting a persistent transmission execution gap, it said in a statement.



Ind-Ra projects a 32 GW mismatch between generation and transmission for projects to be commissioned by H2, FY27. This gap may widen to 40 GW, if interstate transmission system (ISTS) commissioning is delayed by three more months

beyond the current commissioning timelines.

If a project operates ahead of transmission readiness, it must use temporary general network access (T-GNA), which can lead to curtailment due to grid constraints. Ind-Ra-rated renewable

FROM THE WORLD

PAKISTAN

15 killed in road accident

At least 15 people, including women and children of a family, died after a three-wheeler vehicle fell into a canal reportedly due to overspeeding in Punjab province of Pakistan, authorities said on Wednesday.

The rickshaw was carrying 26 wedding guests when it fell into the canal on Tuesday in Kot Addu, Muzaffargarh district of Punjab, some 350 km from Lahore.

The Punjab Emergency Rescue 1122 said in a statement on Wednesday that three rickshaws were carrying a wedding procession from one village to another when one of them lost control due to overspeeding and fell into the Muzaffargarh Canal. "A rescue operation was launched after three people swam through the canal and alerted Rescue 1122."

US

Woman pleads guilt to trafficking

A New York woman has pleaded guilty to her role in an international smuggling conspiracy that illegally brought people, primarily from India, into the United States across its northern border.

Stacey Taylor, 43, of Plattsburgh, New York, was involved in a failed human smuggling operation in January 2025 involving people from India who were illegally brought into the United States.

According to court documents, US Border Patrol agents stopped Taylor's vehicle near Churubusco, New York and discovered four men inside her vehicle.

Agents then determined that the four men – three from India and one from Canada – had just illegally crossed the US-Canadian border without inspection in freezing weather. When law enforcement later examined Taylor's cellphone. After law enforcement stopped her vehicle, Taylor admitted that she picked up the four men to receive payment for doing so. (AP)

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Moscow

Russian President Vladimir Putin on Wednesday threatened retaliation for Western seizures of its commercial vessels, describing them as "piracy."

Speaking on a visit to a Russian warship that was taking part in a naval exercise in the Pacific, Putin described the Western moves to detain vessels linked to Russia as a breach of international maritime law.

"It's nothing but piracy and robbery," Putin said. "If this is done, we will be forced to respond in kind."

He added that the Russian response wouldn't necessarily come in the waters where



Russian President Vladimir Putin visits the Varyag missile cruiser of the Pacific Fleet to watch a military exercise near Yuzhno-Sakhalinsk, on Sakhalin Island, Russia

Thai Government vows tougher gun controls after two deadly shootings near Bangkok

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Bangkok

The Thai Government on Wednesday pledged to tighten gun controls and crack down on illegal firearms after two deadly shootings near Bangkok in less than a week renewed pressure on authorities to curb gun violence.

The country has one of the highest rates of gun ownership in Asia despite its fairly restrictive gun laws. The two recent shootings, both in Nonthaburi province northwest of the capital Bangkok, have intensified calls for tougher enforcement and tighter controls on firearms.

A student opened fire at his high school and family home on Friday, killing at least eight people and injuring more than 20 before apparently taking his own life, according to police. Three days later, a former lawmaker



was arrested after a shooting at a Government office that killed one person and injured another.

Government spokesperson Lalida Persivatanana said Wednesday that the Government is working to strengthen

gun regulations and crack down on illegal firearms, as well as raising awareness on the responsibilities of and limits on gun ownership.

The ultimate goal is "to find ways to remove guns from people's daily lives as much as possible and make Thai society safer," she said in a statement.

On Tuesday, Prime Minister Anutin Charnvirakul ordered an urgent review of gun regulations, including a suspension of new permits to purchase firearms and a review of existing permits, according to a statement from the Government House.

He also instructed the Interior Ministry to propose amendments to Thailand's gun control laws within 60 days. The changes are expected to bolster the collection of firearms data, tighten controls on the gun trade and increase penalties for offenders.

the Russian ships were seized, noting that Moscow could retaliate "in any area where we see it as necessary and appropriate," including in the Pacific.

The Pacific Fleet chief, Adm Viktor Liina, reported to Putin that the navy was ready to start inspections of the commercial ships serving the "unfriendly nations." He noted that many of the ships operated by British, French and other European carriers fly the flags of other nations, effectively making them a "shadow fleet."

"We have enough assets for inspection and detention of vessels of the unfriendly nations and their shadow fleet," Liina told Putin.

"We are ready to start per-

forming the task."

Russia is believed to be using a fleet of hundreds of ships to evade international sanctions imposed after Moscow sent troops into Ukraine in February 2022.

France and the UK have detained tankers suspected of being of Russia's "shadow fleet" shipping oil in violation of international sanctions. The EU has sanctioned hundreds of "shadow fleet" ships.

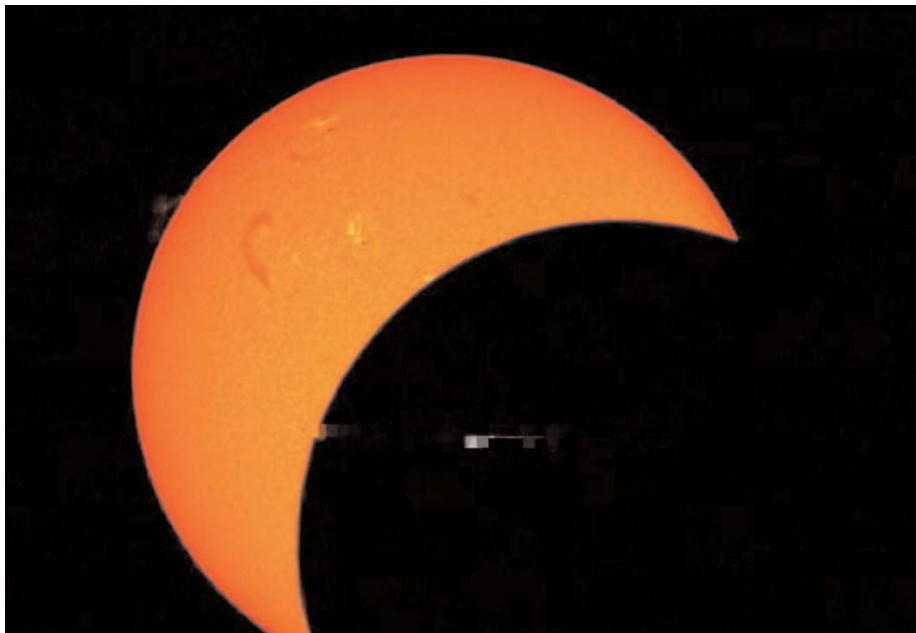
Russia has recently started deploying warships to escort its commercial vessels.

Dmitry Medvedev, who served as Russia's president in 2008-2012 to let Putin observe term limits and is now deputy head of Russia's

Security Council, noted that many ships belonging to European carriers fly the so-called "flags of convenience" just like Russian carriers do.

"It means that by applying a symmetrical approach, which is only fair, Russia has the right to attack any merchant vessel belonging to hostile nations, whether in our waters or in neutral waters, provided there are reasonable grounds to suspect it is carrying cargo in the enemy's interest, and that applies to any cargo," Medvedev said.

"There are a great many such vessels, and our military is capable of dramatically expanding operations well beyond the Black Sea basin."



Minutes before the total solar eclipse caught in Palma de Mallorca, Spain

Hungary's Parliament elects Andras Baka as president as part of Orban-era purge

JUSTIN SPIKE ■ Budapest

Hungary's Parliament elected former Supreme Court chief justice Andras Baka as president as the country's new Government dismantles power structures left behind by former Prime Minister Viktor Orban.

Lawmakers with the governing Tiszta party elected Baka in a secret ballot with 140 votes for and six votes against with no abstentions, while Orban's far-right Fidesz party boycotted the vote.

Baka is expected to be sworn in on August 19. The role of president in Hungary is largely ceremonial, though the president does have the power to send bills back to lawmakers or to the Constitutional Court for review. Prime Minister Peter Magyar's Government has argued that the purge of officials appointed during Orban's time in office is necessary to restore democratic norms and institutional integrity that were eroded during his tenure.

Orban and Fidesz have accused the new Government of "tyrannical" policies, which Magyar and Tiszta deny. In comments in Parliament following his election, Baka crit-



Former Supreme Court chief justice Andras Baka

icized the performance of Orban's four successive Governments and said one of the biggest challenges facing Hungary was the deep social and political polarisation during the former leader's 16 years in power.

Baka added that while past legal and financial abuses must be investigated and prosecuted and democratic institutions restored, political change in Hungary should not come through "revenge."

Indian physicist wins prestigious 2026 Dirac Medal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ London

Indian physicist Deepak Dhar has won the prestigious 2026 Dirac Medal, one of the world's leading honours in theoretical physics, for his "important contributions to statistical mechanics".

Dhar is one of four physicists to receive this year's medal, the International Centre for Theoretical Physics (ICTP), the Italy-based organisation which issues the award.

Dhar is a professor at the International Centre for Theoretical Sciences of the Tata Institute of Fundamental Research (ICTS-TIFR) in Bengaluru. The Dirac Medal, established in 1985, recognises major contributions to theoretical physics. Its past recipients include



Indian physicist Deepak Dhar

several scientists who later went on to receive some of the world's highest scientific honours, including the Nobel Prize and the Fields Medal. Dhar shares the 2026 medal with Bernard Derrida of France, Marc Mezard of Italy and Haim Sompolsky of Israel and the US.

The four were recognised for work that has helped

scientists understand complex systems and has applications ranging from biology and financial markets to computer science and artificial intelligence.

The ICTP said the four scientists were honoured for their contributions to statistical mechanics, a branch of physics that helps explain how the combined behav-

iour of large numbers of particles or other individual elements can produce complex patterns.

Dhar is particularly known for his work on the "sandpile model", which helps explain how a system can remain stable for a long time but suddenly undergo a major

The approach has since been used to study seemingly unrelated phenomena such as earthquakes, traffic jams and fluctuations in financial markets.

ICTP Director Atish Dabholkar, who chairs the medal selection committee, said the work of the four recipients had helped establish statistical mechanics as a powerful framework for addressing questions far beyond its traditional field, including biology, computer science and artificial intelligence.

PUBLIC NOTICE

My client Sh. Avinash Chauhan, hereby informed that my client has disowned and debarred his son Yash Chauhan and daughter-in-law Upasana Rawal from his movable and immovable properties/assets. My client, his wife and daughter have been harassed and threatened with false cases. Hence, they shall have no concern with my client or his properties/assets.

R.S. Sharma, (Advocate) Ch. No. 177, Block-second Complex, Delhi-110001

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that share certificate number 5912/7486/1487/13306/13201/13202/27122/27113/27114/6923/62624 for 288 equity shares each of Rs. 10/- (Rupees Ten Only) (face value) bearing Distinctive No. (S) 2013/02/0002/242648/242673/242674/242675/443035/443039/443066/443067/443085/443094/137548/137678/137698/137697/137698/137699/347682/347683/347684/347685/347686/347687/347688/347689/347690/347691/347692/347693/347694/347695/347696/347697/347698/347699/347700/347701/347702/347703/347704/347705/347706/347707/347708/347709/347710/347711/347712/347713/347714/347715/347716/347717/347718/347719/347720/347721/347722/347723/347724/347725/347726/347727/347728/347729/347730/347731/347732/347733/347734/347735/347736/347737/347738/347739/347740/347741/347742/347743/347744/347745/347746/347747/347748/347749/347750/347751/347752/347753/347754/347755/347756/347757/347758/347759/347760/347761/347762/347763/347764/347765/347766/347767/347768/347769/347770/347771/347772/347773/347774/347775/347776/347777/347778/347779/347780/347781/347782/347783/347784/347785/347786/347787/347788/347789/347790/347791/347792/347793/347794/347795/347796/347797/347798/347799/347800/347801/347802/347803/347804/347805/347806/347807/347808/347809/347810/347811/347812/347813/347814/347815/347816/347817/347818/347819/347820/347821/347822/347823/347824/347825/347826/347827/347828/347829/347830/347831/347832/347833/347834/347835/347836/347837/347838/347839/347840/347841/347842/347843/347844/347845/347846/347847/347848/347849/347850/347851/347852/347853/347854/347855/347856/347857/347858/347859/347860/347861/347862/347863/347864/347865/347866/347867/347868/347869/347870/347871/347872/347873/347874/347875/347876/347877/347878/347879/347880/347881/347882/347883/347884/347885/347886/347887/347888/347889/347890/347891/347892/347893/347894/347895/347896/347897/347898/347899/347900/347901/347902/347903/347904/347905/347906/347907/347908/347909/347910/347911/347912/347913/347914/347915/347916/347917/347918/347919/347920/347921/347922/347923/347924/347925/347926/347927/347928/347929/347930/347931/347932/347933/347934/347935/347936/347937/347938/347939/347940/347941/347942/347943/347944/347945/347946/347947/347948/347949/347950/347951/347952/347953/347954/347955/347956/347957/347958/347959/347960/347961/347962/347963/347964/347965/347966/347967/347968/347969/347970/347971/347972/347973/347974/347975/347976/347977/347978/347979/347980/347981/347982/347983/347984/347985/347986/347987/347988/347989/347990/347991/347992/347993/347994/347995/347996/347997/347998/347999/348000/348001/348002/348003/348004/348005/348006/348007/348008/348009/348010/348011/348012/348013/348014/348015/348016/348017/348018/348019/348020/348021/348022/348023/348024/348025/348026/348027/348028/348029/348030/348031/348032/348033/348034/348035/348036/348037/348038/348039/348040/348041/348042/348043/348044/348045/348046/348047/348048/348049/348050/348051/348052/348053/348054/348055/348056/348057/348058/348059/348060/348061/348062/348063/348064/348065/348066/348067/348068/348069/348070/348071/348072/348073/348074/348075/348076/348077/348078/348079/348080/348081/348082/348083/348084/348085/348086/348087/348088/348089/348090/348091/348092/348093/348094/348095/348096/348097/348098/348099/348100/348101/348102/348103/348104/348105/348106/348107/348108/348109/348110/348111/348112/348113/348114/348115/348116/348117/348118/348119/348120/348121/348122/348123/348124/348125/348126/348127/348128/348129/348130/348131/348132/348133/348134/348135/348136/348137/348138/348139/348140/348141/348142/348143/348144/348145/348146/348147/348148/348149/348150/348151/348152/348153/348154/348155/348156/348157/348158/348159/348160/348161/348162/348163/348164/348165/348166/348167/348168/348169/348170/348171/348172/348173/348174/348175/348176/348177/348178/348179/348180/348181/348182/348183/348184/348185/348186/348187/348188/348189/348190/348191/348192/348193/348194/348195/348196/348197/348198/348199/348200/348201/348202/348203/348204/348205/348206/348207/348208/348209/348210/348211/348212/348213/348214/348215/348216/348217/348218/348219/348220/348221/348222/348223/348224/348225/348226/348227/348228/348229/348230/348231/348232/348233/348234/348235/348236/348237/348238/348239/348240/348241/348242/348243/348244/348245/348246/348247/348248/348249/348250/348251/348252/348253/348254/348255/348256/348257/348258/348259/348260/348261/348262/348263/348264/348265/348266/348267/348268/348269/348270/348271/348272/348273/348274/348275/348276/348277/348278/348279/348280/348281/348282/348283/348284/348285/348286/348287/348288/348289/348290/348291/348292/348293/348294/348295/348296/348297/348298/348299/348300/348301/348302/348303/348304/348305/348306/348307/348308/348309/348310/348311/348312/348313/348314/348315/348316/348317/348318/348319/348320/348321/348322/348323/348324/348325/348326/348327/348328/348329/348330/348331/348332/348333/348334/348335/348336/348337/348338/348339/348340/348341/348342/348343/348344/348345/348346/348347/348348/348349/348350/348351/348352/348353/348354/348355/348356/348357/348358/348359/348360/348361/348362/348363/348364/348365/348366/348367/348368/348369/348370/348371/348372/348373/348374/348375/348376/348377/348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Sino-India border generally stable at moment: China

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

China on Wednesday said the situation along the Sino-India border is "generally stable at the moment" while declining to comment on reports of stepped-up Chinese military activity near the Arunachal Pradesh border.

Foreign Ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun made the comments while responding to media queries about whether there has been a recent military incident with India and if China has increased its military activity near the State, which China claims as part of South Tibet. "The China-India border situation is generally stable at the moment," Guo said. China and India held the 36th



Foreign Ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun

meeting of the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on China-India Border Affairs last week, he said. "The two sides agreed to maintain communication via diplomatic and military channels and jointly uphold peace and tranquility in the border areas," he added.

India on Tuesday said it considers matters relating to border areas with China as "most serious" and asserted that maintaining peace and tranquillity along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) is of "utmost importance", as the state of the frontier will govern the overall trajectory of bilateral ties. The remarks came amid reports of aggressive posturing by Chinese troops in Arunachal Pradesh's

Upper Subansiri region. New Delhi also trashed Beijing's criticism of its decision to formally identify 27 places and geographical features in Arunachal Pradesh by their standard names, emphasising that the state is an "inalienable and integral" part of India and nothing can change this "indisputable reality".

India and China rolled out a series of measures in the last over one year to rebuild their relationship after it came under severe strain following the deadly Galwan Valley clashes in 2020 and the subsequent military face-off that lasted for over four years. In October 2024, the two sides firmed up a disengagement pact for Depsang and

Demchok, the last two friction points in eastern Ladakh.

Days after the agreement was finalised, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping held talks in Kazan and took several decisions to improve the ties.

In August last year, Modi travelled to the Chinese city of Tianjin to attend the annual SCO summit. Modi and Xi held extensive talks on the sidelines of the SCO (Shanghai Cooperation Organisation) summit.

In the meeting, Modi said India is committed to taking forward its ties with China based on mutual trust, respect and sensitivity. In the last few months, India and China initiated a series of measures to reset their ties. (PTI)

Mini-Mozart heist: 210 statuettes stolen from tribute



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Salzburg

More than 200 gold statuettes of Austria's most famous composer disappeared from his hometown of Salzburg, officials said Wednesday, leaving a tribute to Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart on his 270th birthday considerably less crowded. The Mozarteum Foundation on July 15 unveiled 320 statuettes, barely 50 centimeters (less than 20 inches) high, showing

Mozart with his dog. They were designed by German conceptual artist Ottmar Horl.

Within two weeks, more than 80 of the polymer figures had disappeared. By Wednesday, a total of 210 were missing.

"The worst thing for an artist is when his work dissolves," Horl told the German news agency dpa. He said he did not believe visitors stole the works but rather that it was an "organised theft".

Iranian-backed Houthis kill 6 in attack on vessel

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Sanaa

Yemeni authorities said six people were killed by Iran-backed Houthi rebels attacking a vessel in the Bab el-Mandeb strait, while US forces fired on a ship they said was trying to break a blockade of Iran's ports.

Yemen's coast guard said the dead included four crew members and two members of the Government-allied National Resistance Forces. Houthis fired three ballistic missiles at the Yemeni commercial vessel, according to the Transportation Ministry of Yemen's internationally recognized Government.

They are the first known deaths from Houthi attacks on shipping off Yemen in the latest bout of fighting in the Arab country. With the Strait of Hormuz effectively shut down by Iran, there has been a renewed focus on the Red Sea and Bab el-Mandeb strait at Yemen's southern tip, which is an alternate route for Saudi Arabia to ship its oil. The deadly vessel strike came amid Houthi attacks on the Government-held port city of Mokha on the Red Sea and other



areas of the country. Dozens of Government troops and civilians have been killed in attacks since last week, according to the Yemeni military.

The strikes are part of an escalation by the Houthis against Government forces in Yemen and oil facilities in neighbouring Saudi Arabia, which supports the Yemeni Government, and the kingdom's shipping in the Red Sea. The Houthi attacks could reignite Yemen's civil war following a 2022 truce, and open a new front in the West Asia war.

Mohammed Abdul-Salam, the Houthis' chief negotiator and spokesperson, accused Saudi Arabia in a social media post of exploiting the ceasefire to tighten

an air and sea blockade it imposed in 2015. He said the Houthis are open for negotiations but any settlement must include lifting the blockade.

The US military said Tuesday that its forces fired on a Panamanian-flagged ship in the Gulf of Oman that tried to evade the American blockade on Iranian ports.

The move came as US President Donald Trump tries to keep economic pressure on the Islamic Republic.

US Central Command said the vessel had ignored warnings to stop, prompting an American helicopter to fire missiles into the engine room of the M/V Vela Nova, disabling the ship.

Naqvi meets Iran's President

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Islamabad

Pakistan Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi has held talks with Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian and Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi in Tehran to follow up on the stalled US-Iran peace negotiations.

An interim peace agreement, which Pakistan signed as a guarantor, derailed last month as tensions escalated in West



Asia with the US and Iran resuming military strikes. Islamabad is actively pushing to revive its mediation efforts to end the US-Iran conflict.

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is publicly notified that the residential Flat No-57B, Block-H, Sector-22 Noida Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar U.P., Allottee of Mr. R.Chinna Durai S/O V.M Ramakrishnan R/o H-57B, Sector-22 Noida, has sold on the basis of General power of attorney to the following persons. The General power of attorney was registered on dated 03.03.1997, in the name of Mr. P. Padmanabham S/O M.P. Subramanian R/o H-57B Sector-22 Noida and agreement to sell is not executed. Because agreement to sell is not executed so it is publicly notified that the transfer of the property bearing Residential Flat no-57B, Block-H, Sector-22 Noida, Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar U.P. is going to be transfer through G.P.A in the name of Mrs. Indira Devi W/O Sh Miliap Chand R/o H.No.31 B-Block, Prem Nagar, Mathurapur, Delhi, if some one has any objection he/she file his/her objection along with the sufficient proof in the Housing Department (H) of the Noida Authority with in 15 days from the date of publication of this notice.

Signature,
Mr. P. Padmanabham S/o M.P. Subramanian R/O H-57B Sec-22, Noida.

PUBLIC NOTICE

TAKE NOTICE THAT Mr./Mrs./M/s. Sunita Devi residing at/working office at Two BHK Portion No. C1, Second LHS Without Roof Rights, Property No. 173-C/1 And 602/D/9F2, Ward No. 3, Comprising in Kharsa No. 115/2/5 Min. Situated Near Kail Mandir, Abadi of Lal Dora, Village Mehrauli, New Delhi-110030 have agreed to mortgage to my/our client the property more particularly described in the schedule mentioned hereunder written (hereinafter referred to as the said property) free from all charges or encumbrances. All PERSONS claiming any share, interest or right in the said property or any part thereof by way of sale, transfer, assignment, mortgage, charge, lease, license, lien, tenancy, trust, gift, easement, possession, inheritance or otherwise however are hereby required to make the same known to the undersigned in writing, within 14 (fourteen) days from the date of publication of this notice, with all supporting documents, failing which mortgage over the said property shall be created without reference to all claims if any, and the same shall be deemed to be waived and/or abandoned and will not be binding on my/our clients.

THE SCHEDULE ABOVE REFERRED TO (Detail description of the property) Two BHK Portion No. C1, Second LHS Without Roof Rights, Property No. 173-C/1 And 602/D/9F2, Ward No. 3, Comprising in Kharsa No. 115/2/5 Min. Situated Near Kail Mandir, Abadi of Lal Dora, Village Mehrauli, New Delhi-110030 Boundaries to the Property: East: Property of Mrs. Richa Gupta, West: Road/ Road 16/F, North: Property of Mahendra Kumar Sharma / Other Property, South : Gail / R/S Unit Then Gail / F.

2 US states proclaim August 15 as Indian Independence Day



Kathy Hochul

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New York

Two US states, New York and New Jersey, have proclaimed August 15 as "India Independence Day", recognising India's journey as an independent Nation and the contributions of the Indian-American community.

New York Governor Kathy Hochul issued a proclamation declaring August 15, 2026, as "India Independence Day" across the entire state, while New Jersey Governor Mikie Sherrill made a similar declaration, the Indian Consulate in New York posted on X.

The proclamations come ahead of India's 80th Independence Day celebrations and highlight "India's journey of independence and the democratic values shared by India and the United States", the consulate said.

New York and New Jersey, both neighbouring states, are home to some of the largest and most influential Indian-American communities in the United States, with Indian-origin residents making significant contributions across business, healthcare, technology, education and public service, according to the proclamations made by both States.

DEATH TOLL RISES TO 44 AFTER FERRY CAPSIZES ON ZIMBABWE LAKE

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Harare

The death toll after an overloaded ferry capsized on Lake Kariba in Zimbabwe has risen to 44, police said on Wednesday.

Police said on X that the bodies had been retrieved from the lake that forms part of the border between Zimbabwe and Zambia. But police did not update

how many people were injured or still missing after Tuesday's disaster involving a ferry operated by a Government agency.

The ferry capsized while carrying at least 114 adult passengers and five crew members, according to Zimbabwe's disaster management agency. It was not clear how many people were on the ferry because the figures only included those who bought tickets, and children below ticketing age could have been on board.



PUBLIC NOTICE

It is hereby I nformed to the public at large that our client **Mrs. Madhu Jain W/o Mr. Sharat Jain**, R/o House No. 246, Sector - 15A, Noida, Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar (U.P.) - 201301 have **resigned from the LLP firm M/s. "XP Prints LLP" having LLPIN - AAQ-9509**, with effect from **31st May, 2026** and she is no longer partner in the said firm and also have no connection and is not responsible for the business of the said firm in any way on or after **31st day of May, 2026**. Any person / body dealing with the said firm will be doing so with his / their sole responsibility.

Date: **10th Aug.2026**
VIPIN KUMAR (Advocate)
Unit No.B-817, Gaur Cascades Raj Nagar Extn., Ghaziabad. Mob. 9811032863

ReNew Akshay Urja Limited

CIN : U40300DL2015PLC275651
Regd. Office : 138, Ansal Chambers II, Bikaji Cama Place, Delhi-110066
Corporate Office : ReNew.hub, Commercial Block-1, Zone-6, Golf Course Road, DLF City Phase-V, Gurugram, 122009, Haryana, Phone – 0124-4896 670/ 80

Statement of Unaudited Financial Results for the quarter ended 30 June 2026

Particulars	Quarter ended 30 June 2026 (Unaudited)	Quarter ended 31 March 2026 (Audited)	Quarter ended 30 June 2025 (Unaudited)	Year ended 31 March 2026 (Audited)
	(INR in millions)			
Total Income from Operations	478	489	415	1,747
Net Profit for the year (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	278	270	196	879
Net Profit for the year before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	278	270	196	879
Net Profit for the year after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	208	201	147	653
Total Comprehensive Income for the year (Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the year (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax))	208	201	147	653
Paid up Equity Share Capital	133	133	133	133
Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve)	5,165	4,956	4,451	4,936
Equity component of compulsory convertible debentures	1,144	1,144	1,144	1,144
Net worth**	6,442	6,234	5,728	6,234
Outstanding Redeemable Preference Shares *	NA	NA	NA	NA
Debt Equity Ratio *	1.81	1.82	2.01	1.82
Earnings Per Share (of Rs. 10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations)				
1. Basic :	9.10	8.79	6.45	28.57
2. Diluted :	9.10	8.79	6.45	28.57
Capital Redemption Reserve *	NA	NA	NA	NA
Debtenture Redemption Reserve *	309	300	316	300
Debt Service Coverage Ratio *	4.11	1.22	3.53	1.87
Interest Service Coverage Ratio	3.99	3.81	3.08	3.29
Current ratio	7.57	7.16	7.86	7.17
Long Term Debt to Working Capital*	0.95	1.02	1.22	1.02
Total Debts to Total Assets Ratio*	0.33	0.34	0.39	0.34
Current Liability Ratio*	0.13	0.13	0.10	0.13
Debtor Turnover Ratio*	1.43	1.48	0.93	4.06

Disclosures pursuant to Regulations 52(4) and 52(8) Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015.

- Notes :
- Ratios have been computed as follows:
 - Earning per share (Basic and Diluted) = Profit after Tax / Weighted average number of equity shares
 - Debt Equity Ratio = Debt (Amount due to Debenture Holders) / Equity (Equity share capital + share premium + loan from related party - unamortized fees)
 - Interest Service Coverage Ratio = Profit before interest, tax and depreciation / Total Interest Expense
 - Debt Service Coverage Ratio* = (PAT based on Project Revenues realised (excluding non-cash adjustment, if any) + Depreciation + Interest (Interest, Guarantee Fees, other financing costs payable under Debenture and Project Documents)) / (Interest + Principal Repayment+Guarantee fee)
 - Asset Coverage Ratio = (Total Assets) / Debt (Amount due to Debenture Holders)
 - Current ratio= Current Assets / Current Liabilities
 - Long Term Debt to Working Capital = Non-Current borrowing including current maturities of Non-current borrowings/ (Current Assets - Current Liabilities (excluding current maturities of Non-Current borrowings))
 - Bad debts to Account receivable Ratio = Bad debts written off (net of recovery) /Average Gross Trade Receivables
 - Current Liability Ratio= Current Liabilities/ Total Liabilities
 - Total Debts to Total Assets Ratio = Total outstanding debts/ Total Assets
 - Debtors Turnover Ratio = Revenue from operations /Average Trade Receivables
 - Inventory turnover ratio = Company does not generate revenue from selling of inventory, hence this ratio is not applicable.
 - Operating margin (%) = (Profit for the period + Tax expenses + Finance costs - Other income) / (Revenue from operations)
 - Net profit margin (%) = Profit for the period / Revenue from operations
 - Outstanding redeemable preference shares (Quantity and Value): Not Applicable
 - *As per Debenture Trust Deed dated 20 September 2017.
 - ** Network represents issued subscribed and paid up capital plus reserves and surplus. Reserves and Surplus includes Capital reserve, General reserve, Debenture redemption reserve, Securities premium account and Profit and loss account balance.
 - The above is an extract of the detailed format of quarterly financial results filed with the Stock Exchange(s) under regulation 52(4) of the Listing Regulations. The full format of the quarterly financial results is available on the website of National Stock Exchange of India Limited and the listed entity URL(s) <https://www.nseindia.com>
 - For the other line items referred in Regulation 52(4) of the SEBI (LODR) Regulations, 2015, the pertinent disclosures have been made to the National Stock Exchange of India Limited and can be accessed on the URLs <https://www.nseindia.com>.
 - The statement has been prepared in accordance with recognition and measurement principles laid down in accordance with the Indian Accounting Standard "as prescribed under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013 (the Act)" read with Rule 3 of the Companies (Indian Accounting Standards) Rules, 2015 and relevant rules issued thereunder and other recognized accounting practices and policies.
 - The company is in the business of development and operation of renewable energy power. There is only one segment (business and/or geographical) in accordance with the requirements of IND AS - 108 "Operating Segments".
 - The financial results for the quarter ended 30 June 2026 have been approved by the Board of Directors in their meeting held on 12 August 2026.
 - Care Ratings has assigned long term issuer rating and rating for the outstanding non-convertible debentures of the Company to "CARE AA+" with stable outlook.

For and on behalf of
ReNew Akshay Urja Limited
(Sd./) Parul Agrawal
Managing Director, DIN : 08452687

Place : Gurugram
Date : 12 August, 2026

ReNew Wind Energy (Jath) Limited

CIN No. U40101DL2012PLC236227
Regd. Office : 138, Ansal Chambers II, Bikaji Cama Place, Delhi-110066
Corporate Office : ReNew.hub, Commercial Block-1, Zone-6, Golf Course Road, DLF City Phase-V, Gurugram, 122009, Haryana, Phone – 0124-4896 670/ 80

Statement of Unaudited Financial Results for the quarter ended 30 June 2026

Particulars	Quarter ended 30 June 2026 (Unaudited)	Quarter ended 31 March 2026 (Unaudited)	Quarter ended 30 June 2025 (Unaudited)	Year ended 31 March 2026 (Audited)
	(INR in millions)			
Total Income from Operations	127	68	237	730
Net (Loss)/ Profit for the year (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	13	(17)	131	290
Net (Loss)/ Profit for the year before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	13	(17)	131	290
Net (Loss)/ Profit for the year after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	9	(13)	95	216
Total Comprehensive Income for the year (Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax))	9	(13)	95	216
Paid up Equity Share Capital	153	153	153	153
Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve)	2,162	2,153	2,038	2,153
Securities premium	1,366	1,366	1,366	1,366
Net worth	2,315	2,306	2,191	2,306
Paid up Debt Capital / Outstanding Debt	1,589	1,588	1,940	1,588
Debt Equity Ratio	0.92	0.92	1.12	0.92
Earnings Per Share (of Rs. 10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations)				
1. Basic :	0.59	(0.86)	6.20	14.13
2. Diluted :	0.59	(0.86)	6.20	14.13
Debtenture Redemption Reserve	125	122	147	122
Debt Service Coverage Ratio*	0.94	0.40	0.66	1.21
Interest Service Coverage Ratio*	2.32	1.54	4.18	3.23
Current ratio*	1.02	1.00	2.35	1.00
Long Term Debt to Working Capital*	0.97	1.01	1.17	1.01
Current Liability Ratio*	0.81	0.81	0.32	0.81
Total Debts to Total Assets Ratio*	0.32	0.32	0.37	0.32
Debtors Turnover Ratio*	1.35	0.89	1.41	8.16
Inventory Turnover Ratio*	NA	NA	NA	NA
Operating margin (%)	75%	(39%)	68%	50%
Net profit margin (%)	7%	(19%)	40%	30%

Disclosures pursuant to Regulations 52(4), 54(3) and 63(2) Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 (as amended).

- Notes :
- Ratios have been computed as follows :
 - Earning per share = Profit after Tax / Weighted average number of equity shares
 - Debt Equity Ratio = Debt (Amount due to Debenture Holders) / Equity (Equity share capital, share premium, loan from Related party and excluding unamortized fees)
 - Interest Service Coverage Ratio = Profit before interest, tax and depreciation / Total Interest Expense.
 - Current Ratio= Current Assets/ Current Liabilities
 - Long Term Debt to Working Capital= Non- Current borrowing including current maturities of Non-current borrowings/ (Current Assets - Current Liabilities excluding current maturities of Non-Current borrowings)
 - Bad debts to Accounts Receivable ratio= Bad debts / Average Trade receivables and Average unbilled Revenue
 - Current Liability Ratio= Current Liabilities/ Total Liabilities
 - Total Debts to total Assets = Total outstanding debts/ Total Assets
 - Debtors turnover= Revenue from operation/ Average trade receivables and Average unbilled Revenue
 - Inventory Turnover. The company does not generate revenue from selling of inventory, hence this ratio is not applicable.
 - Operating margin(%)= (Profit before tax + Finance costs - Other income) / Revenue from operations
 - Debt Service Coverage Ratio* = (PAT based on Project Revenues realised (excluding non-cash adjustments, if any) + Depreciation+ Interest (Interest, Guarantee Fees, other financing costs payable under Debenture and Project Documents)) / (Interest + Principal Repayment+Guarantee fee)
 - The above is an extract of the detailed format of quarterly financial results filed with the Stock Exchange(s) under regulation 52 of the Listing Regulations. The full format of the quarterly financial results is available on the website of National Stock Exchange of India Limited and the listed entity (URLs <https://www.nseindia.com> & <https://www.renew.com/renew-wind-energy-limited-jath>).
 - For the other line items referred in Regulation 52 (4) of the SEBI (LODR) Regulations, 2015, the pertinent disclosures have been made to the National Stock Exchange of India Limited and can be accessed on the URLs <https://www.nseindia.com> & <https://www.renew.com/renew-wind-energy-limited-jath>.
 - The statement has been prepared in accordance with recognition and measurement principles laid down in accordance with the Indian Accounting Standard 34 "Interim Financial Reporting" ("Ind AS 34") as prescribed under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013 (the "Act") read with Rule 3 of the Companies (Indian Accounting Standards) Rules, 2015 and relevant rules issued thereunder and other recognized accounting practices and policies.
 - The company is in the business of renewable power generation and other ancillary activities. There are no separate reportable segments (business and/or geographical) in accordance with the requirements of IND AS - 108 "Operating Segments" and hence there are no additional disclosures to be provided other than those already provided in the financial statements.
 - The financial results for the quarter ended June 30, 2026 have been approved by the Board of Directors in their meeting held on 12 August 2026.
 - India Ratings and Care Ratings has assigned long term issuer rating and rating for the outstanding non-convertible debentures of the Company to "IND AA (CE)" with negative outlook and "CARE AA (CE)" with stable outlook, respectively.

For and on behalf of the
ReNew Wind Energy (Jath) Limited
(Sd./) Vivek Jaswal
Managing Director, DIN : 03580286

Place : Gurugram
Date : 12 August, 2026

SMFG Grihashakti
Nagpur, India, Nagpur, India

SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd.
Corporate Off.: 503 & 504, 5th Floor, G-Block, Inspire BKC, BKC Main Road, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai - 400051.
Regd. Off.: Commerzone IT Park, Tower B, 1st Floor, No. 111, Mount Poonamallee Road, Porur, Chennai - 600116, TN

SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES
E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE OF 15 DAYS FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE ASSETS UNDER THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 READ WITH PROVISION TO RULE 9(1) OF THE SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES, 2002.
NOTICE is hereby given to the Public in General and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below listed immovable properties ("Secured Assets") mortgaged / charged to the Secured Creditor, the Possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of **SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd.** (hereinafter referred to as **SMHFC**) ("Secured Creditor"), will be sold on "**As is where is**", "**As is what is**" and "**Whatever there is**" on the date and time mentioned herein below, for recovery of the dues mentioned herein below and further interest and other expenses thereon till date of realization, due to **SMHFC** Secured Creditor from the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) mentioned herein below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor's LAN	Description of the Properties	Reserve Price : Earnest Money Deposit :	Date & Time of E-Auction	Date of EMD Submission
1.	LAN : 620638011824294 1. Aditya Singhal S/o. Padam Sain Singhal 2. Neeru Aditya W/o. Aditya Singhal	Flat No. GF-1, Ground Floor (Without Roof Rights) MIG (Gaytri Apartment) Total Covered Area 56 Sq. Mtr. Plot No. 18, Kharsa No. 1564, Kailash Puram Calouni, Phase-II, VIII, Rahipur, Pargana Dasna, Tehsil & District Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh. East : Plot No. 36; West : Plot No. 19; North : Plot Other Owner; South : Road 20 Feet Wide	Rs. 12,00,000/- Rs. 1,20,00,000/-	02.09.2026 at 11.00 a. m. to 01.00 p. m.	01.09.2026

Details terms and conditions of the sale are as below and the details are also provided in our/secured creditor's website at the following link website address (<https://BidDeal.in> and <https://www.grihashakti.com/pdf/E-Auction.pdf>) The Intending Bidders can also Contact **Pankaj Kumar**, on his Mob. No. 7380950199, E-mail : Pankaj.Kumar38@grihashakti.com, Mr. Niloy Dey, on his Mob. 8655619157, E-mail : Niloy.Dey@grihashakti.com

Place : Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh
Date : 13.08.2026

Sd/-
Authorized Officer,
SMFG INDIA HOME FINANCE CO. LTD.

PROSPECT

Riniki Bhuyan Sharma, Chairperson and MD of Pride East Entertainment Pvt Ltd, distributed cheques worth ₹1 crore to 20 schools in the flood-affected districts of Assam

UCO Bank organises Retail, MSME, Resource & Agri Carnival

UCO Bank, Mid Corporate Gurugram Branch, organised a Retail, MSME, Resource & Agri Carnival on Tuesday at Club Florence, Gurugram.

The programme was graced by the esteemed presence of Shri Gautam Patra, Chief General Manager, Business Development, New Delhi, and Shri Prem Shankar Jha, Chief General Manager, Head Office, Kolkata. A large number of customers, entrepreneurs and businesspersons participated in the carnival and obtained information about various financial schemes and services being offered by the Bank. The objective of the programme was to raise awareness about retail, MSME, agriculture and other banking products and to provide suitable solutions in line with the financial requirements of customers.

During the programme, bank officials interacted with the participants and shared detailed information about various loan schemes, banking facilities and financial options related to business expansion. Officials from the Zonal Office, New Delhi, along with branch managers from various branches, were also present on the occasion.

(PNS)

IIFL Finance launches special gold loan for women

Leading non-banking financial company IIFL Finance on Wednesday announced a special gold loan offering for women borrowers in the run-up to Independence Day, designed to help women entrepreneurs and homemakers convert idle household gold into productive capital. The offering is available at IIFL Finance gold loan branches across India. The scheme offers a special interest rate starting from 0.81 per cent per month (9.72 per cent per annum) at zero processing fees for women borrowers. The scheme also provides maximum permissible loan value against the customer's gold, within the loan-to-value limits prescribed by the Reserve Bank of India. Mayank Sharma, Head – Gold Loan, IIFL Finance, said, "For millions of Indian women, the gold in the cupboard is the most valuable asset they own, and for generations it has done nothing at all. A gold loan changes that, without asking her to part with it – she pledges, she borrows, she repays, and her jewellery comes home."

(PNS)

India's ethanol supplies cross 800-crore-litre mark

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's ethanol programme has crossed a new supply milestone of 800-crore-litre mark during ESY 2025-26, with grain-based feedstocks strengthening their share of monthly supplies in July, according to the latest data compiled by the All India Distillers' Association (AIDA).

A total of 93 crore litres of ethanol was supplied during July, taking cumulative supplies beyond the 800-crore-litre milestone. Grain-based feedstocks accounted for 71 crore litres, or around 76 per cent of July supplies, compared with approximately 73 per cent in June, when grain-based ethanol contributed 75 crore litres out of 103 crore litres supplied during the month.

The month-on-month movement is significant because grain-based supplies remained relatively stable even as total monthly ethanol supplies moderated, resulting in a higher share for grain-



based feedstocks in July.

The July data also highlights a notable shift within the grain-based segment.

Maize and surplus FCI grains each contributed 30 crore litres of ethanol in July, together accounting for nearly 85 per cent of grain-based supplies during the month. Damaged food grains contributed a further 11 crore litres.

The near-equal contribution from maize and surplus FCI grains underlines the increasing role of multiple grain streams in supporting ethanol supplies. It also demonstrates the flexibility of the domestic ethanol supply

NCDFI, Indian Army reaffirm commitment to strengthen dairy supply chain

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

National Cooperative Dairy Federation of India Ltd (NCDFI) and the Indian Army reiterated their commitment to strengthening cooperation to support local milk procurement, processing and cold-chain management through the dairy cooperative network.

"This unique four-decade old Dairy Cooperative-Defence partnership delivers benefits to all stakeholders – defence establishments gain dependable supplies and resilient local supply chains; cooperatives secure assured institutional markets and better utilisation of infrastructure; and dairy farmers access wider markets with regular income," said Meenesh Shah, Chairman, NCDFI, who also heads the National Dairy Development Board (NDDB).

Speaking at the "Cooperative Conclave on Dairy-Defence Partnership" in Anand, Gujarat, Shah commended cooperatives for strengthening milk procure-



ment, processing, cold storage and supply-chain systems in border and North-Eastern regions. He said every additional litre supplied brings dairy farmers and personnel serving the nation closer together.

The Conclave recognised the contribution of dairy cooperatives in supplying quality milk and milk products to Defence establishments, particularly in remote, border and high-altitude areas.

Lt General Mukesh Chadha, Director General of Supplies and Transport (DGST), Indian Army, appreciated NCDFI and its member cooperatives for ensuring reliable supplies to troops in difficult terrains. He also complimented NDDB for its

Conflict begins within the individual, says philosopher Acharya Prashant

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Greater Noida

A delegation from Shyam Lal College (Evening), University of Delhi, led by its Principal, Prof Nachiketa Singh, held a public dialogue with philosopher and author Acharya Prashant on the theme "Conflict Resolution and Human Security."

In a rare gesture, rather than host the philosopher on its own campus as is customary for such lectures, the college brought its faculty and students to a college auditorium in Greater Noida, close to Acharya Prashant's residence. The session began with an interaction between Acharya Prashant and Prof. Singh, followed by audience questions. Prof. Singh, a senior political science faculty member with nearly three decades of teaching and research, holds a doctorate on ethnic conflict in the former Yugoslavia and works across international rela-



tions, foreign policy and security studies.

He opened by asking Acharya Prashant for a philosophical lens on a subject usually approached through diplomacy and statecraft.

Acharya Prashant located the origin of conflict not in borders or institutions but in the individual. "It is only the human species that requires peace," he said, arguing that human conflict is largely psychological. He traced it to the ego, which he said sets human beings apart from other life forms and makes education necessary. "Only

running car," he said.

He was blunt about career insecurity, calling the corporate world far less fearsome than students imagine and warning that the real mistake is entering a field one has no relationship with. "Attitude matters a little more than even aptitude," he said, adding that mismatched work breeds life-long conflict.

When Prof. Singh asked about the pressures families and the economy place on the young, Acharya Prashant said agency rests with parents and teachers rather than young children, since each generation passes its own conditioning to the next. That cycle, he said, breaks only where upbringing and schooling make room for mass education of the self, an effort he has taken up through his PrashantAdvait Foundation.

He then extended the argument to the environment.

Assam begins four-day plantation drive under Brikshya Bandhu initiative

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Minister for Environment and Forest Jayanta Mallabarua ceremonially launched the 'Brikshya Bandhu' initiative at the Sri Sri Damodardev International Auditorium, Srimanta Sankaradeva Kalakshetra, Panjabari, Guwahati, marking the beginning of a four-day statewide plantation drive involving more than 22 lakh students from Class VI onwards. Under the initiative, students across Assam will plant more than 1.5 crore saplings from August 11 to 14 as part of the Amrit Brikshya Andolan.

The initiative has brought together 11,277 educational institutions across the State, with 2,128,495 students already registered for the plantation drive. The Forest Department has distributed 1.57 crore saplings to participating educational institu-



tions till now.

Seven educational institutions took part in the central launch programme in Guwahati, while students and institutions across the State joined the programme through online platforms.

Addressing the gathering, Minister Baruah thanked the students, teachers, Education Department and officials of the Forest Department and all those associated with this initiative. He said the programme aims not only to increase tree cover but also to develop a lasting sense of responsibility among the younger generation towards planting, protecting and nurturing trees.

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (12.8.26)

7	2	3	5	8	1	4	6	9
5	9	6	4	2	7	8	3	1
4	8	1	9	3	6	5	2	7
3	7	2	1	9	4	6	8	5
1	5	4	8	6	2	9	7	3
9	6	8	7	5	3	2	1	4
2	3	9	6	1	5	7	4	8
6	4	5	3	7	8	1	9	2
8	1	7	2	4	9	3	5	6

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

THURSDAY | AUGUST 13, 2026

ACROSS

4 Evil ways we all have (6)

7 Is sweet, but can make you sick in a sticky coating (8)

8 Creature confused by clouts (6)

10 A backward fool keeping himself to himself (5)

13 Here's your chance to play detective (4)

14 Go round, or simply go (4)

15 Price is both officer and saint (4)

16 One side is insufficient for the whole game (3)

17 Is it much the same as Iraq? (4)

19 Public address I'd settled the bill for (4)

21 A bunion, say, won't help a tennis player (4,5)

23 Transferred foreign currency to the capital of Turkey (4)

24 Despite appearances, it doesn't mean "from" (4)

26 He's a bit decadent (3)

27 The part of a toaster that dries (4)

29 Beat back in a game (4)

32 Continental region to fly from briefly

33 Dramatically put on a coach (5)

34 What's new in battleship construction

35 They follow the horses and are number ten in the charts (8)

36 Pretentiously artistic outfits for church

15 Some secateurs can scratch! (3)

16 Left it switched on? (3)

18 They go round or up over hills (6)

20 The childless total frequently is high (5)

22 A life dependence requirement

22 A social worker (3)

23 Tasteful girl with a French boyfriend (6)

25 Perform at the gala opening, if you follow (3)

28 One has a feeling it may be dropped (5)

30 Provide as an instalment (3,2)

31 All swans? Not really (5)

32 Restful little part of the country (4)

33 Humble member of the baser fraternity

1 Being so small, it can get out of traps (5)

2 First lady to be seated, in a sense (5)

3 Something to sing about when smelling it? (4)

4 Finds a market for sound electric batteries (5)

5 Pleasant looking resort (4)

6 Being out of the wood, we'd cleaned up

9 Product with which a shifty tout admits turning up (6)

11 Pull by the ear (3)

12 It's bulbous yet skinny (5)

13 To make a mess is a bewildering thing to do (7)

DOWN

1 M-Alice

7, Accident

8, Sets

10, Ku-wait

11, Design

14, A-le

16, Mated

17, Da-B-s

19, Deb-ag

21, Ta-Ken

22, Bayed

23, Reap

26, Lear-n

28, Per

29, Engage

30, Pick-up

31, Apes

32, Tenderly

33, Swells

1, M-arked

2, Ideals

3, East

4, Fireman

5, Debit (card)

6, Stand

8, S-W-AB

9, Tie

12, Sag

13, C-Emma

15, Pokes

18, Ali-EN

19, Day

20, Bed

21, Tangled

22, (Bar-) Bra

23, Reced-E

24, Erks

25, Papers

26, Letts

27, A-gin-G

28, Pip

30, Pays

Over 1,000 children embrace preventive health and healthy living in Noida



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than 1,000 children came together at The Millennium School, Noida, for the fourth edition of 'Bachchon Ka Maati-IV' and emerged as young ambassadors of preventive health and wellness. Organised by Maati Trust in association with Illness to Wellness (ITW), the initiative combined health and hygiene awareness with creativity, fitness and value-based learning, equipping children with simple, practical messages that they can carry beyond the event and share with their families, peers and wider communities.

The initiative aims to create a ripple effect of preventive health awareness, with these 1000 young ambassadors taking the message of healthy habits, hygiene, nutrition and physical activity into their homes and communities.

A key highlight of the initiative was the Illness to Wellness handwashing and hygiene activity, through which children were trained in the importance of proper handwashing and everyday

hygiene practices.

Anil Rajput, Chairperson, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation, said, "Preventive healthcare cannot begin in hospitals. It must begin at home, in schools and through the everyday habits we build from an early age. When children understand the importance of hygiene, nutrition and physical activity, they do not merely improve their own health; they become powerful ambassadors of wellness within their families and communities. Initiatives like Bachchon Ka Maati help make preventive health engaging and relatable, while giving children the knowledge and confidence to spread these messages further." The event also featured a prize distribution ceremony, with Dr Mahesh Sharma, Senior Member of Parliament and former Minister, as the Chief Guest and Mritunjay Pratap Singh, Director, RVNL, as the Guest of Honour. Addressing the children, Mahesh Sharma shared several mantras for success in life and stressed the importance of adopting a healthy lifestyle.



Delhi unveils new tourism circuits at Spiritual & Heritage Tourism Conclave 2026. The conclave was graced by Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and spiritual leader Sadhguru.

Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar

Advertisement No. 11/2026

Online applications are invited for the Non-Teaching posts in the University. Online registration of application for the post will start w.e.f. 13.08.2026 and end on 04.09.2026. Last Date for submitting Hard Copy of the Online submitted application is 16.09.2026. For further details visit University Website: <http://www.digital.gndu.ac.in>

Amritsar 12.08.2026

2426/12/2026-27/14138 Dated CHD - 12/08/2026

REGISTRAR

GURU NANAK DEV UNIVERSITY, AMRITSAR

TENDER NOTICE

Online tender are invited from reputed manufacturers/authorized dealers for the Rate Contract for supply of Chemicals, Glassware, Plasticwares and Equipments etc. (upto Rs. 2,00,000/-) for the period 2026-27. Earnest Money (Rs. 20,000/-) may be deposited online latest by 2/09/2026 (till 5:00 pm). Online Tender Form, Terms & Conditions are available on www.gndu.ac.in

Director of Research

2426/12/2026-27/14139 Dated CHD - 12/08/2026

GVK Power (Goindwal Sahib) Limited

Regd. Office: Plot No.10, Paigah Colony, Sardar Patel Road, Secunderabad-500003 Telangana, India CIN: U40109TG1997PLC028483

(A wholly owned subsidiary of Guru Amar Das Thermal Power Limited, GATPL)

(A step down wholly owned subsidiary of Punjab State Power Corporation Limited (PSPCL))

HOD-C&I, GATPL, Goindwal Sahib, invites E-Tender for the work of:

1 Tender Enquiry No. 186/GATPL/MD/DTG/20017969 Dated 12-08-2026

"Procurement of Auma MOV Spares"

Area of 2x270 MW Thermal Power Plant (GATPL, Goindwal Sahib)

At 2X270 MW Guru Amardas Thermal Plant (GATPL, Goindwal Sahib, Distt. Tarn Taran, Punjab as per details given in the tender specifications.)

For detailed NIT & tender specifications, please refer to <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in> from 12/08/2026 from 17:00 Hrs. onwards.

Note: Corrigendum and addendum, if any, will be published online at <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in>

GATPL-79/26

1079/12/2026-27/14169 Dated CHD - 12/08/2026

BRIEFLY

Depay says, disappointed at Corinthians for breaking contract



Netherlands forward Memphis Depay plans to “react strongly” after saying that Brazilian club Corinthians did not honor an agreement to extend his contract.

Depay said on social media he was “very disappointed” to find out Corinthians decided “not to honor our agreement in place to extend my contract for 2 more years.”

“This renewal was explicitly agreed upon by the president as well as the sporting, legal and financial department,” he said. “Some people decided however to breach this engagement...” Depay joined Corinthians in 2024 and helped the club win the Brazilian Cup last year.

“I didn’t want this situation and always respected the club throughout the process, but now I am forced to react strongly in order to preserve my interests,” he said. (AP)

Man City signs Rulli as back-up goalkeeper to Donnarumma



Manchester City’s back-up goalkeeper to Gianluigi Donnarumma will be Geronimo Rulli after the Argentina international joined from Marseille on a two-year deal on Wednesday.

The 34-year-old Rulli replaces James Trafford as City’s second-choice goalie. Trafford left to join Leeds last week.

Rulli, who has played eight times for Argentina and was part of the World Cup-winning squad in 2022, has European experience after playing at Real Sociedad, Villarreal, Montpellier, Ajax and most recently Marseille since 2024.

He had a brief spell at City in the 2016-17 season.

“I have been really impressed by him during our conversations, a strong desire to join us,” City director of football Hugo Viana said. “It’s clear we are getting a brilliant professional, as well as a top keeper.” (AP)

Coby Bryant to miss four to six months after knee surgery



Chicago Bears safety Coby Bryant will miss four to six months after he had surgery on his injured left knee, coach Ben Johnson said. Bryant, signed to a \$40 million, three-year deal as a free agent this offseason, was expected to be an important part of a revamped Chicago secondary.

Johnson said Bryant had surgery Friday without disclosing details of the injury. He did not rule out the possibility that Bryant would return this season.

“I got to see him today,” Johnson said. “He’s going to be in a hurry to get back to help us out there at the end of the year.” Bryant was hurt at practice on Aug. 3. (AP)

PSG looks for Super Cup success over Aston Villa for first of six possible trophies this season

STEVE DOUGLAS ■ Paris

Paris Saint-Germain gets back on the trophy trail on Wednesday in the UEFA Super Cup against Aston Villa. There are six pieces of silverware up for grabs for PSG this season, with the No. 1 priority being a third straight Champions League title to cement its status as one of the greatest club teams in soccer history. The first trophy could be lifted inside Red Bull Arena in Salzburg, Austria, in the annual match between the most recent winners of the Champions League and Europa League. It starts at 9 p.m. local time (1900 GMT).

PSG is bidding for a second straight Super Cup win after beating Tottenham in a penalty shootout last year.

Villa won the Super Cup in 1983 after beating Barcelona over two legs. The manager, Unai Emery, has experienced three straight losses in the Super Cup - the first two with Sevilla and the third with Villarreal.

Referee is Somali official barred from World Cup

The game will be refereed by Omar Artan, the



Somali who was barred by the United States from officiating at the World Cup days before the start of FIFA’s tournament because of vetting concerns. U.S. officials claimed Artan had connections to terror organizations, though without

providing proof.

UEFA responded by picking Artan — a referee judged the best in Africa last season — to take charge of the Super Cup in a powerplay by European soccer’s governing body amid its increasing disconnect with FIFA. That disharmony has increased since, with UEFA leading the campaign to oust Gianni Infantino from the FIFA presidency over his recent -aborted- plan to sell an interest in the World Cup. (AP)

Fencing team secures five more medals at Commonwealth title

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

The Indian fencing team collected three gold, one silver, and one bronze medal across various senior individual events on the third day of the Commonwealth Champion ship in Lagos, Nigeria. Dominating the field in senior women’s foil, senior men’s epee, and senior men’s sabre, Team India’s stellar day three performance brought the nation’s overall combined medal count to an extraordinary 29 medals — comprising 8 Gold, 7 Silver, and 14 Bronze.

India established immediate dominance in the senior women’s foil category, securing a gold-silver victory.

Kanaglakshmi captured the gold medal following a precise and controlled campaign, while teammate Joys Ashitha took silver to claim the top two spots on the podium ahead of England’s Georgia Green and Emily Goodchild, who won Bronze.

The success continued in



the Senior Men’s Epee discipline, where Rajendran Shanthimol Sherjin put on a commanding display to secure India’s second gold medal of the day.

Sherjin outpointed South Africa’s Kruger Pieter, who finished with silver, while Wales’ Burkhardt Marc and South Africa’s Losevsky Sergey shared the bronze

medals.

In the senior men’s sabre event, Singh Karan Singh clinched India’s third gold medal of the day with an outstanding final fight against Australia’s Shim Yoongi, who took silver.

Teammate Kumaresan Padma Gisho Nidhi added to the medal haul by winning bronze alongside Nigeria’s Akinyosoye Oluwafolayemi.

With the championship wrapping up on Wednesday, the Indian contingent turns its focus toward the final events across foil, epee, and sabre disciplines.



Praggnanandhaa beats Javokhir Sindarov in Sinquefield Cup

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ St Louis (USA)

Indian Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa crashed through the defences of Javokhir Sindarov in a second round match to register his first victory of the Sinquefield Cup, the penultimate event of the Grand Chess tour, here.

The star of the day was Praggnanandhaa all the way as the Indian claimed his point inch-by-inch in the endgame arising out of a queen pawn opening.

Sindarov, who will be up against world champion D Gukesh later this year for the world crown, chose just an equal endgame that should



have been a perfect draw for him. But then what he possibly did not account for was Praggnanandhaa’s

tenacity. It paid off in the end for the Indian as from what the computer was claiming to be a drawn

Don’t let pressure affect your game: Sreejesh ahead of WC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Former India hockey goalkeeper PR Sreejesh has urged the current players not to let the pressure of the World Cup affect their game, asking them to trust their preparation and enjoy the occasion.

The FIH World Cup will be jointly hosted by Amstelveen, Netherlands, and Wavre, Belgium, from August 15 to 30.

The Indian men’s team is led by ace drag-flicker Harmanpreet Singh, while the women’s side is captained by Salima Tete.

The men’s team, which has won back-to-back Olympic bronze medals at Tokyo 2020 and Paris 2024, will aim to end its long World Cup podium drought. India last finished on the podium in 1975, when it won gold.

“The FIH World Cup is the second biggest tournament in hockey after the Olympics and naturally, the whole world is watching, and all eyes are on you. That brings a lot of pressure,” Sreejesh said.



“But you cannot let that pressure affect your game. When you start thinking too much about it, your performance drops. And when your performance drops, the pressure increases even more. So the key is to stay calm, focus on your role, and trust your training,” said the 38-year-old goalkeeping great, who was part of both of India’s bronze-winning Olympic campaigns. The Indian men’s team is placed in Pool D and will play the opener against Wales on August 15. They will then take on England and Pakistan on August 17 and 19 respectively.

Strong field of 157 players to compete in Asian Junior Chess Championship

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

A strong field of 157 players from 10 countries, including six International Masters and 24 FIDE Masters and Women FIDE Masters, will compete in the Asian Junior Chess Championships here from August 16 to 26. The tournament, featuring Asia’s top U20 talent, will comprise nine rounds of Classical Swiss, along with seven rounds each of Rapid and Blitz. It is being held under the aegis of the All India Chess Federation, Asian Chess Federation and FIDE, and hosted by the Maharashtra Chess Association.

The event has previously crowned several prominent players, including Viswanathan Anand, Abhijit Kunte and Tejas Bakre in the open section, and Tania Sachdev, Koneru Humpy and Ivana Furtado in the women’s section.

The winners will earn a Grandmaster norm if they are already IMs, while non-IMs will be



eligible for an IM norm.

The Classical event will feature 157 players, while 153 will compete in Rapid and 151 in Blitz. The Open section has an average Elo rating of 2054, compared to 1885 in the junior women’s section.

Indian IM Mayank Chakraborty (2500) heads the open field, followed by Russia’s IM Artem Pigin (2477) and India’s IM Apporv Kamble (2441).

In the junior women’s section,

India’s WFM Pratitee Bordoloi (2252) leads the field, ahead of Kazakhstan’s WFA Mariya Kholyavko (2217) and Turkmenistan’s WFM Lala Shohradova (2159). Other Indian players to watch include Vignesh Advait Vemula (2405), Aaditya Dhingra (2403) and Akshay Borgaonkar (2396), while WFM Swara Lakshmi Nair (2155), Mrityika Mallick (2153) and Saranya Devi Narahari are among contenders in women’s section.

Jeev Milkha Singh to Kapil’s PGTI: Indian golfers should be allowed to play anywhere they want

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

Indian golfing stalwart Jeev Milkha Singh has urged the Kapil Dev-led PGTI to not bar players from participating in the Indian Golf Premier League (IGPL) as they have every right to earn “good livelihood” and build their game through such events.

The 54-year-old owner of four European Tour and six Asian Tour titles said that while he understands that every Tour has its own set of rules and regulations but once a player fulfils his commitment towards that Tour, he should not be stopped from exploring other avenues.

The Professional Golf Tour of India has prohibited golfers, who choose to compete in the IGPL, from playing in PGTI events, making it clear that it would not share talent with the league that was co-founded by another World Cup-winning cricket hero Yuvraj Singh. “You could have two tours or three tours but at the end of the day, it’s a player’s tour. If they are gaining then there should not be any restriction whatsoever. If they can make a good livelihood out of it, nothing like it,” said the affable man from Chandigarh, arguably the greatest Indian golfer of all time.

“...you could have differences, you could feel like, my tour is better than



yours, but at the end of the day, if the players are gaining by playing on any tour, it’s fantastic,” Jeev told PTI in an exclusive interview from Tokyo on Wednesday.

While maintaining that there is room for both PGTI tournaments and IGPL to co-exist, Kapil Dev has also made it clear that the players will have to pick a lane and no leniency would be shown towards those who decide to play IGPL.

However, despite the strict public position, Kapil has also urged veteran Gaganjeet Bhullar to reconsider his decision to play in the IGPL.

Jeev said once a player is done doing his duties on PGTI, he should not

be held back from playing his trade elsewhere.

“I think every tour has a certain commitment regarding the number of events you’ll have to play. I agree with that also. But if you’re committed to X amount of events as a member then you should be allowed to play other tournaments, which are going to make you a better player and get you a better livelihood,” he emphasised.

Jeev, who is now an active member of the senior tour, cited his own example. “I play on the Japanese senior tour. I have to play 10 events out of the X amount of events they have in a year. If I’m committed to playing those 10 events, I can go play anywhere else in the world.

“On the European tour, my commitment is a minimum of six events. I can go play anywhere after six events. I play 10 in Japan, but I play 12 in Europe. So, there’s no restriction,” he pointed out. Jeev said the IGPL, a four-week event which debuted this year featuring 60 players, is a very good pathway from domestic golf to the international stage. “The relationship between IGPL and the Asian Tour has become better over the years. They’re giving a few spots to the players to get into the final stage and also giving one spot to the top player so that he can play on the Asian Tour,” he said. (PTI)

Dickwella returns to Sri Lanka Test squad; Nuwantha gets maiden call-up

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Galle

Wicketkeeper-batter Niroshan Dickwella returned to Sri Lanka's red-ball set up after three years, while off-spinner Keshara Nuwantha earned his maiden call-up as the hosts named a 16-member squad for first Test against India. Dickwella, who last played a Test against New Zealand in 2023, is in line to make his return to the format after regular wicketkeeper Kusal Mendis was ruled out with an injury.

Besides Nuwantha, uncapped batter Pasindu Sooriyabandara and left-arm pacer Dilshan Madushanka have also been included in the squad, which features four specialist fast bowlers. Madushanka's return adds further variety to Sri Lanka's pace attack, which also comprises Asitha Fernando, Lahiru Kumara and Vishwa Fernando. All-rounder Milan Rathnayake provides another seam-bowling option.

Nuwantha, meanwhile, could make his Test debut after building an impressive record in domestic cricket.



The right-arm off-spinner joins left-arm spinner Prabath Jayasuriya and Ramesh Mendis in the spin department. The squad also includes experienced all-rounders Kamindu Mendis and Dhananjaya de Silva. Dhananjaya De Silva leads the side while Kamindu Mendis will serve as his deputy. The first Test

against India begins here on Saturday. Sri Lanka squad for First Test against India: Dhananjaya De Silva (c), Lahiru Udana, Nishan Madushka, Kamindu Mendis (v-c), Dinesh Chandimal, Pasindu Sooriyabandara, Sonal Dinusha, Niroshan Dickwella (wk), Ramesh Mendis, Prabath Jayasuriya, Keshara Nuwantha, Milan Rathnayake, Asitha Fernando, Lahiru Kumara, Vishwa Fernando, Dilshan Madushanka.

Miller wants to finish on high by winning 2027 ODI World Cup

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

South African batting stalwart David Miller wants to end his career on a high by winning next year's ODI World Cup, calling it a "goal" he hopes to achieve in front of the home fans. The tournament will be co-hosted by South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia in October-November next year and will feature a revamped format comprising a preliminary stage, group stage, Super 7 and knockout rounds.

Miller, 37, who has featured in several domestic franchise leagues, including the IPL, also said he takes pride in his role as a middle-order batter who comes in to finish games.

"Yeah, I am really

looking forward to it (2027 World Cup). For me, it's a goal that I want to achieve. I would love to finish off late in my career with a trophy," Miller said.

"So, for me, it's a goal that I would love to be a part of that World Cup team. It's something that is never guaranteed, and I'll definitely, from now until then, be focused on aiming to make that team and to contribute the best I can. "Obviously, it will be very special, being at home in front of our fans, and in a place that I've played for so many years. So, it would be fantastic to be a part of that team," he added.

Miller said batting in the middle order and staying until the end to finish games required a certain mastery, something he has relished throughout his career.

"Probably the fact that I've made a career by batting in the middle order and finishing games, that would be something I'm most proud of. It's something that takes a long time to kind of conquer and master.

"I'm still learning all the time, but at least I've had a long career in that department, and I've really enjoyed going about chasing innings, especially," he added.



Australia launch 20-Test year in Top End against depleted Bangladesh

KEIRAN SMITH ■ Darwin (Australia)

Test cricket returns to Australia's tropical Top End for the first time since 2003 when the hosts face Bangladesh in a two-match series starting Thursday.

The series opener at Marrara Stadium in Darwin marks Bangladesh's first test tour Down Under in over two decades and kicks off a 12-month period of at least 20 test matches for the Aussies including tours of world test champion South Africa, India and England.

Australia's so-called Big Four bowling attack is set to be reunited in Darwin with Pat Cummins, Josh Hazlewood and Nathan Lyon returning from injuries. Pace bowlers Cummins, Hazlewood and Mitchell Starc and offspinner Lyon have been the longtime front line attack for Australia but injuries have limited the frequency of all four combining in the same XI in recent series.

Hazlewood's expected inclusion comes at the expense of the



evergreen Scott Boland, while allrounders Cameron Green and Beau Webster have also been named in Australia's starting team.

"We know Scotty's class, it is always a pretty tight call," said captain Cummins at a pre-match press conference Wednesday. "There is not much you can say

to Scotty except there is a lot of cricket coming up. "He knows his worth, and how good he is, and I am sure he will be out there at some point pretty soon."

While the bowling unit is settled, it's Australia's batting lineup that poses more questions. (AP)

Rahane to make Test commentary debut during India-Sri Lanka series

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Former India batter Ajinkya Rahane is set to make his Test commentary debut during the team's upcoming two-match series in Sri Lanka. He will join the Sony Sports Network commentary panel for the series that begins in Galle on August 15.

Rahane, who recently brought the curtains down on an illustrious playing career spanning nearly 18 years after making his first-class debut, will take up a new role behind the microphone, bringing his experience of international red-ball cricket to the broadcast. The 37-year-old Rahane played 85 Tests for India, scoring 5,077 runs at an average of 38.46, including 12 centuries and 26 half-centuries. He also led India to a memorable Test series triumph in Australia in 2020-21 and was part of several memorable overseas victories as a middle-order batter.

"I'm excited to make my Test commentary debut for India's tour of Sri Lanka on the Sony Sports Network and Sony LIV. Test cricket is the pinnacle of our sport, and having represented India in the format for so many years, it is a privilege to now look at the game from a different perspective," Rahane said.



‘Era of randomly scheduling bilaterals over, reinvention needed in Tests, ODIs’

BHARAT SHARMA ■ New Delhi

The era of "randomly" scheduling bilateral series is over but the much-debated ODI format can continue to survive and thrive with its place "inextricably" linked to the World Cup, International Cricket Council (ICC) CEO Sanjog Gupta has asserted in an interview to PTI.

Gupta, a leading figure in the business of sport, had joined the ICC in July last year. He shared his thoughts on the Test and one-day formats at a time when their future has been constantly debated in the age of mushrooming T20 leagues.

"The era of randomly scheduled bilateral series has to come to an end, because countries will not be able to sustain cricket without context, culture, competition and competitiveness, which require significant investment of resources, both financial and non-financial," Gupta said.

"It's important to stay focused on the four levers which drive attention and affiliation -- context, culture, competition and competitiveness -- and ODIs can continue not just to survive, but thrive.

"There is a place for the format in the product portfolio, which is inextricably linked to men's and women's ICC Cricket World Cups. We need to look at what we



want the format to stand for and how we want it to evolve, including the expanse of participation," he noted.

Bilateral cricket is decided exclusively by the member boards without ICC's intervention. The world body only handles the scheduling of multi-national competitions like the World Cups and the World Test Championship. The Boards retain the sponsorship and media rights of bilateral engagements. As things stand, only the big three -- India, England and Australia -- can afford to play Tests while the other full members are struggling to monetise the longest format. (PTI)

India lock T20 series against Afghanistan in September

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Bangladesh's hopes of hosting India for a long-pending white-ball rubber in September seem all but over with the BCCI announcing that Shreyas Iyer and his men will face Afghanistan in a three-match T20I series in Delhi from September 13 to 17.

The BCCI and the Afghanistan Cricket Board (ACB) announced the series in a joint statement on Wednesday, the window for which clashes with



the plans that Bangladesh had proposed. The Indo-Bangla bilateral series had to be postponed last year due to the political

unrest in that country.

The games against Afghanistan are a part of ACB's Future Tours Programme. They are being treated as a home assignment for the ACB, which has made India a base for

conducting games in recent years due to the volatile political situation in Afghanistan.

The series will get underway on September 13, with the second T20I scheduled for September 15 and the third on September 17. All the three matches will be played at the Arun Jaitley Cricket Stadium here.

Afghanistan most recently toured India for a three-match ODI series in June, and the two sides also played a three-match T20I series in January 2024.

India hosted Afghanistan for their historic first Test in 2018, and the two teams have since continued to engage regularly across formats.

NEROCA down nine men FC Raengdai to end group stage campaign with a win

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Imphal

NEROCA FC came from behind to beat nine-man FC Raengdai 3-1 and end their group-stage campaign on a winning note in the 135th IndianOil Durand Cup at the Khuman Lampak Main Stadium on Wednesday, 12 August 2026.

FC Raengdai took the lead in the 19th minute through Jonah Kamei, but NEROCA restored parity eight minutes later after Thoudam Nani Singh turned the ball into his own net. Raengdai were reduced to nine men in the second half after P.M. Rakeveiche and Soraisham Surjakanta Singh were shown red cards within four minutes of each other, forcing the side from Noney to play the final 30 minutes with nine players.

NEROCA took the lead in the 89th minute when substitute Chabungbam Linky Meitei headed home to put his side ahead. Yumnam Renedy Meitei then added a third in stoppage time to complete the comeback. The victory saw NEROCA finish their Group D campaign with four points from three matches, while FC Raengdai, who had already secured their place in the quarter-finals, finished with six points from their three matches.

NEROCA FC head coach Yumnam Raju Mangang made five changes to his starting XI for their final match of the tournament. Naorem Kiranjit Singh replaced Abujam Penand Singh in goal, while Soibam Abhinash Singh and Lambalmayum Hembra Meitei came into the defence in place of Ben Nash



Quansh and Saphaba Singh Telem. Sinam Maichael Singh replaced Charles Teiko Folley in midfield, while Sridarth Nongmeikam came into the attack in place of Ngathem Imarson Meitei.

Meanwhile, FC Raengdai head coach Kshetrimayum Birbal Singh made three changes to his side, who had already secured their place in the quarter-finals. Yaithengbam Suraj Singh came in between the posts in place of captain Kamei Pantiga, with Jonah Kamei replacing Wahengbam Rojen Meetei in defence and taking over the captain's armband. Thoudam Nani Singh was also handed a start in midfield in place of Gaisuangmei Kamei.

NEROCA FC registered the first attempt on goal inside the opening three minutes after Sibajit Singh found space inside the box to control a pass from Maichael Singh. However, the forward failed to make clean

contact with his effort, which drifted wide of the post without troubling the goalkeeper. Moments later, FC Raengdai thought they had taken the lead when Amarjit Singh produced an acrobatic finish after connecting with a pass from Amitkumar Singh, but the effort was ruled out for offside.

FC Raengdai took the lead after gradually establishing control of the contest. Jonah Kamei peeled away from his marker to meet a corner and powered a header towards the bottom corner. The effort beat both the goalkeeper and the defender stationed on the goal line to give Raengdai the advantage.

NEROCA had a couple of opportunities to restore parity from their own set-pieces, with Zidan Singh failing to keep his headers on target on both occasions. They eventually found the equaliser by capitalising on a defensive error from FC Raengdai.

Organisers defend European championships ticket prices after sparse crowd in Birmingham

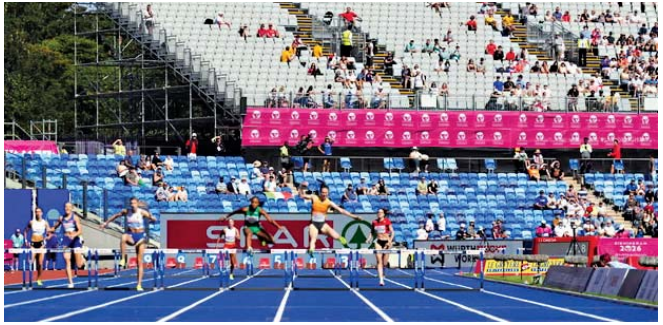
KEN MAGUIRE ■ London

Organisers of the European championships have defended ticket prices in Birmingham after British sprinter Amy Hunt won the 100-meter final at a nearly half-empty Alexander Stadium.

One of Olympic champion Keely Hodgkinson's coaches was among those questioning prices and raising concerns about parking and the cost of food - with bratwurst hot dogs going for 15 pounds (\$20).

The category A seats for Monday night's session - which included Jakob Ingebrigtsen's victory in the 5,000 meters and Hunt's gold - cost 150 pounds (\$202). The cheapest adult ticket was 26 pounds (\$35).

Official attendance Monday night was 13,623, though journalists on hand said the actual figure seemed lower, in a stadium with capacity at 23,000.



"Hearing from fans re high ticket prices, parking issues; even people not knowing it was taking place," Jenny Meadows, a coach of Hodgkinson, wrote on social media. Commentator Sonja McLaughlan added: "Actually a bit shocked at type of prices being charged. It's a shame for the athletes who deserve better. The sport has this precious window without football, free to air television exposure and it

looks flat with such a sparse crowd."

The morning sessions - during which the athletes compete in qualifying rounds - offer lower prices. Ticket prices for Tuesday's and Wednesday's evening sessions top out at 110 pounds (\$148), before reverting to the higher prices Thursday through Sunday. Organisers said Tuesday that more than 50 percent of tickets were priced at 30 pounds (\$40) and lower. (AP)

Pakistan's Arshad Nadeem to skip DL meet in Lausanne



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lahore

Pakistan's Olympic gold-medallist javelin thrower Arshad Nadeem will skip the Diamond League meet in Lausanne this month to focus on preparing for another international event and the Asian Games in Japan this year.

Arshad's long-time coach, Salman Butt, said the javelin thrower was presently training in Lahore but would soon leave for South Africa, where he will train for a few weeks under his coach, Terseus Liebenberg, and local trainers. "He has decided against competing in the Diamond League meet this month as he wants to be ready for the Asian Games," Butt said.